Sisters Of The Road

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37142293.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Other Side Characters - Relationship

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - 1930s, speakeasy, so much slang, Fluff and Smut, First Times, Love at First Sight, Alternate Universe - Historical, Spopcreativeflex, Smut Swap, more tags to come, 1933 specifically, Chicago (City), the great depression, Semi Public Sex, Emotional Sex, any place is risky when your gay in the 1930s, Next to no angst for once, good job me, Found Family, I finally get to write Wrong Hordak

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English

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SPOP Flex Smut Swap, Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

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Sisters Of The Road

by RaptorRed

Summary

Adora just wants to buy a hot dog, look for work and take care of her found family.

Catra just wants to see the city, maybe make a few cents and rejoin her friends to venture off to another part of the country.

Neither of them expected to stick up a man with fresh hands, make off with a bounty, go on a string of dizzying dates with their ill gotten gains, and fall impossibly in love.

Notes

See last posted chapter end notes for the slang index.

Lolo, when I got you for the swap, I knew I had to do this idea. We can still do something like this together if you're interested, but I hope you enjoy it. It might take me just a tad longer than the swap date to finish it because of what's been happening in my life, but It shouldn't be long!

Love you friend! I hope you enjoy this!

And not in order of events, a playlist: https://open.spotify.com/playlist/3av0rHNqC9Rs94Fpv2krgy?si=1PJZIGtWQq2fcI1Z97TiXg

See the end of the work for more notes

The Chicago Canary and The Georgia Peach

The drab remnants of her coin purse wouldn't multiply, no matter how many times Adora poked around in there. At least she had enough for both the hotdog and a cola. If enough people came in tonight, she might just have enough to splurge for more than a bag of roasted peanuts tomorrow.

Adora confidently produces the two nickels pinched between her fingers. The young man at the cart starts looking around, eyes darting to her sides and then he stretches on his toes to look behind her. Confused, Adora looks around too, arm still outstretched. There didn't seem to be anything there worthy of a looky-loo, just other Chicago-iets going about their day. Probably pounding the pavement for now hiring signs, just like she is.

When she faces him again, he's beaming at her, and her stomach flips uncomfortably. Not again. She just wants to eat.

"Say, I think just one nickel is all I need. Your name's bound to more than cover the rest, doll." He says with a wink and what she supposes is a cheeky smile.

Adora smiles right back. One nickel saved today meant another meal for another day. "Adora, and you?"

He rocks on his heels and reaches out for her hand. She intends to drop the coin into it, but instead he touches her hand, lingering on fingertips a little too long before taking one coin. "One happy fella, is what you can call me. Or Will can work in a pinch too."

"Well, thank you, Will." Adora says with a well practiced laugh. He seems so pleased with himself, rocking and whistling as he places the soda on the edge. Adora had a half a mind to cut out just with the bottle before she needs to figure out a way to shoot this man down.

“You know-“ He starts waving the hot dog around with the tongs and as a result, a splash of hotdog water from this weenie of a man flecks her face. Adora’s plastic smile doesn’t falter, but the hunger growing inside is eroding her tolerance a bit faster than usual. “you’re a little taller than most girls I’m attracted to.”

“Oh?” She holds her hand out for the damn hot dog, now that it’s securely in a bun. “Well, you were still lookin’. Don’t think I didn’t notice, you tomcat, you.” The cheesy growl she ends with was sure to put the man off, but no, he takes his time to rake his eyes up and down her body, her food still very much in hand. It takes every ounce of willpower to not snatch the hotdog out of his hand before he sets it down.

She slips the coin pouch into her bag and collects her hard earned prize calmly, like a normal person. A sigh almost escapes her lips when the fool pipes up again before she can turn tail and run.

“Hold up, sweetheart.” He rounds the cart and steps uncomfortably close, making her step back, but not far enough to avoid his hand on her shoulder. Adora is about two seconds away from decking this grease ball, and most definitely is going to if that hand gets any fresher. “I’m out of here in about twenty minutes, my brother’s taking over. What do you say to sticking around and letting me take you dancing tonight? I’m no cement mixer, I’ll dance your socks off baby.”

There is no way in blazes that this man is going to be taking anything off of her. She is about to say as much when an arm incircles her waist. Adora jerks her head around with a scowl, hoping to see the face of the man she’s about to elbow in the ribs and freezes. The red in her eyes fades as Adora comes face to face with the most handsome woman she’s ever seen. Two shocking different eyes, a soft and yet strong jowl with the rosiest sun kissed cheeks spattered with freckles, all shaded under an olive cap. Her heart does something akin to a somersault and she stops mid inhale.

“Honey, is this punk giving you trouble?” Her voice lilts with a shallow southern twang and is hoarse with an obviously fake deepness. What is this lady doing?! Air finds her lungs again, risk assessment overtaking whatever world stopping experience came over her. Adora’s gaze falls downwards, over the cotton button up shirt and dark linen trousers. The hotdog man was about to go from intolerable to troublesome seeing this woman bold enough to wear men's clothing head to toe in public cuffing up next to her.

“Ah, sorry pal.” Will backs up, much to Adora’s surprise, and holds his hands up placatingly. “I was just asking her out, she didn’t tell me she had a fella.”

Adora bites back a *“I shouldn’t have to.”* but this stranger surprises her even more.

“I don’t think she should have to, *pal.”* The arm around Adora’s waist falls away as the woman steps forward, moving toe to toe with the vendor. She stares him in the eyes and reaches into the steamer, not even bothering with tongs. The stranger places the dog into a waiting bun, and holds it aloft. She’s still up in the man’s face and holding the hot dog threateningly, somehow. “I think this is mine, for putting your paws on my girl.”

Will swallows nervously, and that’s when Adora notices the woman’s other hand holding a pocket knife pressed to the man's gut. “Of course, Sir.”

“Say you’re sorry.”

“I’m sorry-“

“To her, not me, you jackass.”

Will’s eyes go wide as he looks at Adora, and in spite of herself, she smiles wickedly. Do not come between a woman and her food, especially a woman that can lay you flat on your ass. “Sorry, uh, ma’am.”

With a flash of light glinting off the blade, the knife disappears into the stranger's pocket and she turns heel, wrapping her free arm around Adora's. Adora doesn't even have time to think about protesting as she's spun around, scrambling to keep up with the brisk strides.

"Sorry for spooking you like that, but you looked ready to wallop that guy. I rather have ketchup than blood all over my food." The gruff facade is gone, but her voice has a raspy sweetness to it that's burning Adora's ear as she whispers into it. "I'll apologize properly in a minute but we need to make tracks before he notices."

Well that would explain the pace, but she still has no clue why they need to make a quick getaway. He fell for her being a man just fine. "Notice what?"

Adora's new company throws her a brilliant smile, one she's not sure she can tear away from but does when this gorgeous stranger lifts her own hotdog in front of them, three singles flapping between the bun and her fingers. It was probably the only change available if someone swung by the cart with a Jefferson. Will is definitely going to notice. Adora's mouth drops. She just wanted a soda and a bite, she hadn't ordered an unwanted flirt with a side of stick-up. Adora is about to protest as much until an angry yell interrupts their silent exchange of aghast and amusement.

"Get back here you thievin' bastard!"

Of all things Adora expects to come out of this woman's mouth as they flew, it sure as hell wasn't giggles. She also isn't exactly sure why she is still following this broad, but here she is, trying to keep her coke and food from falling as she's led down the street. "Where- where are we going?" Adora pants between laughter that's spilling from her lips, the raspy cackling seems to be contagious.

Adora doesn't get her answer, at least not until they get at least two blocks away, and even then Adora thinks they only stop because the only other option is to take a dive into the river. The sly thief plops down onto a bench, and beams up at Adora.

Her cheeks are rosy from their run, only making her freckles pop more in the sun, her smile is exploding a dozen beams of light deep into Adora's chest and when they lock eyes Adora opens her mouth to say… *something, anything,* but she can't. They're both staring at each other, mouths agape that turn into broad smiles until this beautiful stranger clears her throat.

The sound of shoes on pavement, cars in the busy street and the low roar of the Chicago river return, along with at least half of Adora's wits when sunshine and freckles pats the empty spot on the bench next to her. "Join me? I don't bite, promise."

Adora's mind retorts with an automatic "shame", but thankfully a much less revealing, and a far more sensible sentence rolls off of her tongue instead. "Ah, but are you gonna snatch my purse if I do?" She asks playfully, not actually at all worried about the possibility. "Can I at least get your name first, before I'm party to another crime?"

The woman laughs nervously, licking her lips like Adora isn't already curious as to what they taste like and she at least looks a tad shameful. "Look, I don't typically go around snatching cabbage, but when I see a dog treat a lady like that…" Her head lilts to the side coyly before she shrugs. "I'm filled with chutzpah."

Adora smiles at her, smoothing down her dress as she sits down. "Chutzpah, huh?" There's a question there, the most she hoped for was a name from this dashing dame, but she'll take any knowledge of her like it's free candies and she's ten again.

"Yeah," Freckles starts with a sweet laugh, "my good friend Lonnie says I have plenty of it. That's why her and the fellas don't trot with me anymore when we land in the city. She says I'm trouble on two feet." Her eyes grow wide, and Adora can feel the corners

of her mouth pulling impossibly tighter. “Wow! I’m not really selling myself here am I?” She blushes, turning away from Adora to take a bite of her ill gotten hotdog.

Adora just laughs right back, a bit too enamored to start on her own hard won food in spite of her growling stomach. “Well, not really, no.” The woman faces her again, her hand covering her mouth to keep food from flying as she chuckles. “I do tend to attract trouble though, so I’m not surprised. Your good friend Lonnie calls you that *and* …?”

The stranger looks like she’s about to respond, but keeps chewing and glancing at Adora’s coke.

In one smooth motion, Adora pops the cap off on the metal of the bench, her nights tending bar finally paying off in the light of day and for an attractive woman at that. She totally isn’t reading into the lingering touch as the bottle departs from her hand. The woman takes a swig and holds it out tentatively.

“Catra, is my name.” She says with a smile, brushing the back of Adora’s hand with a thumb as Adora takes the bottle, and a sip for herself. “And who’s my new partner in crime?”

Between weenie man and the impromptu escape, the delayed hunger gets the better of her now that sugar has hit her lips. “Adora.” She muffles through her own mouthful of food. “An I’m not abou’ elp’ you swin’le anyone else, par’ner.”

“That’s more than fine, and I think it’s only fair that you get a cut, for all your suffering.” Catra slips one of the three greenbacks down on the bench as Adora chews away.

She eyes it, and Catra’s shy smile. She really shouldn’t take it. Sure, she might be party to illicit activities once or twice a week, if she’s lucky, but that’s different. It’s a safe haven, a place for people she’s come to know as family to be themselves, for her to be herself. But also, a dollar is a lot of money. It’s a lot of potatoes to feed said family.

Catra raises a brow and slowly starts sliding it back towards herself. With a sigh Adora plucks it off of the bench and slips it into her hand bag. "Well that's, one for me, and two for you I guess? Nice to know how much my suffering is worth to you."

"Exactly one dollar." Catra says confidently, but pulls out one more and puts it between them. "I do have an idea though. It's my last day here, and I don't think I've taken a big enough bite out of this apple yet. This dollar could do a lot if a local wanted to show me where we could spend it, together?"

Adora takes another sip of her coke to chase the last of her food down, and passes off the rest to Catra. They trade the dollar for the bottle and she holds it up, considering. It's not like her job hunt is going to go any better today than it has any other day. Hearing that it's Catra's last day in town is also something she wasn't glad to hear. A disappointment that logically shouldn't be there. It's obvious from her soft southern accent that she's not from here, but people come to the city all the time to chase their dreams, not realizing it's just the same as everywhere else. You're not going to find the glamour and glitz in Chicago, New York or L.A no matter how many promises the picture palaces make through the projector. All the same it would be a shame though to pass up an afternoon with this magnetic woman. She has to be magnetic, with how strongly Adora wants to say yes after only a brief exchange of words and dab of chaos thrown into her day.

There was also the question of whether or not Catra was homosexual, or just very friendly and dressed in dapper for other reasons. Adora would in the streets too, if she wasn't such a familiar face to so many in the area, and if it weren't a risk to her family. "Penny for your thoughts first?"

Catra leans toward her, bringing the bottle to her lips, and Adora stares, blatantly. Catra notices, as intended, and her mouth curves into a suggestive smile. If a bird talks like a gay woman, acts like a gay woman, is looking at another gay woman like that, well, she must be a gay woman. That question silently asked and

answered, Adora moves on with her next. “Your good friend, Lonnie, just how *good* of a friend is she?”

Catra rolls her eyes. “Oh *please.* What do you take me for? An egg?”

“I’m still deciding if I’m taking you at all.” Adora quips back, leaning away now, crossing her arms and trying not to look too pleased at the red creeping across Catra’s face.

“Just a friend, family really. She’s got two fellas actually, who are good good friends of each other too.”

“Good for her!” Adora means it too, it isn’t just a wave relief as she leans back toward the space between them, even further this time. “Good for all of them!”

“I‘ll say! We have one other with us, but she’s also just family. I don’t have any *good, dear friends,* to keep me company.” Catra’s eyes look hopeful, and she places her hand on Adora’s, the one holding the bill. “But, weather I make any today or not is okay, either way I have a feeling that we’d have a blast burning this dollar down to nothing.” They’ve gotten awfully close now, and Adora has no intention of stopping her. “Whad'ya say? Keep this poor, lonely fool of a woman company?” Catra finishes in a whisper against Adora’s ear.

Catra’s plea is finished but her breath is still hot on Adora’s neck, sending goosebumps to her skin and tingles down her spine. She swallows past the tension in her neck and moves their joined hands to rest on Catra’s thigh. “I might have some ideas for some entertainment today.” She really shouldn’t, not if she’s going to have to say goodbye to this inexplicable pull towards her just as soon as she begins to explore it. Carpe Diem, as Bow likes to say. It worked for him once he finally took his own advice with Glimmer. To be fair to him though, they were all under the same roof, fed and employed by Glimmer's parents.

All Adora has to worry about is to be left with longing, that and a beat cop or stranger cracking this shell thin facade Catra's wearing. But… doesn't she have to worry about this everyday, anyway? Isn't it better to taste this forbidden fruit dangled in front of her, calling her like a siren, than to be left wondering? Adora's tasted from the orchard before, sweet, bitter and satisfying all at once. But not one of them has left her with this heavy weight in her chest like this Georgia peach is.

Adora moves both their hands up Catra's leg, her breath hitching as Adora's fingers trace lightly on the inside until she reaches her destination of Catra's pocket and she tucks the bill back in there. "Yeah, I think I will." Adora stands abruptly, Catra's hand still in hers and tugs the smaller woman to a stand. "There's a new museum that just opened up, where they had the world fair. Let's go see what all the gabs about."

It wouldn't be too far to walk, but if Adora only has one afternoon to spend, she's going to make it count and so they swing onto one of the street cars headed the direction they need to go. Admittedly, she's a bit nervous when they step on, hand in hand. To Adora it's obvious that Catra is in fact a brilliantly beautiful, handsome woman but no one seems to say anything. They did get a look from one gal as they sat in the back, arm in arm, but that look was followed by a wink and a turn away. To everyone else it must just look like a man and his flame cozied up together.

"How…" Adora starts, comfortably settled under Catra's arm over her shoulders as they zip down the street. She'd like to wrap her own around Catra's waist, but doesn't want to push this luck that her male clad companion seems to have, to discover the curve of her waist under the loose shirt. At the start and stop of Adora's half formed question, Catra leans in, picking up on Adora's want for privacy, and as a good excuse to get a breath away again. As curious as Adora is, there's also something honey sweet about the way Catra smells and what this intimate closeness is doing to her that makes Adora wish, for once in her life, for a touch of frigidity "How are you just able to-" Adora swallows when Catra tucks a stray lock behind her ear. "- walk around like this?" She whispers.

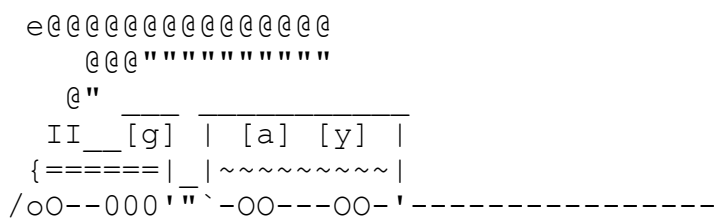
Catra’s fiery gaze softens, and Adora realizes the envy that must have snuck into her tone and expression.

“I’m not in one place a lot, and I find that in the cities people see what they want to see. No one paid us mind as we ran, yeah?” Catra says softly, and Adora nods. “In the small towns we stop in…” Catra trails off and Adora eyes her, the apprehension as clear as the oh so kissable looking nose on her face. “...they see us get off the train and no one cares. Most of the women on the rails with us dress like this. They just assume it's for easier travel, and it is. A dress on the car is a pain, but that's not the only reason. We get to live, uh, the life. No one bats an eye when you're curled up with your travel companion, your sister on the road.” Adora lets out a puff of air, a bit dazed at the prospect of getting to saddle up like this all the time, not just in back room of the Queen’s laundry joint, slinging bathtub gin, worrying that at any moment a copper could put an end to it all.

“It's not eggs in coffee all the time, but we do pretty well, even if that means you’re sorta slumming it right now, doll.”

Adora rests her head briefly on Catra’s shoulder as a silent reassurance that she is not at all slumming it, but also to gather herself back from the unexpected ache Catra’s words brought her. This charming stranger has the audacity to swoop in, spare that weenie man from a broken nose, be impossibly gorgeous, enigmatic off the bat, and she now tells Adora that there’s a way that their people can share love outside the confines of a hidden room?

She doesn’t dwell on it long, not knowing that this date (she thinks that this is a date.) has a definitive ending of parting ways. She has to work tonight, and Catra is going to leave the city. This is just going to be like every other date she’s been on though very unplanned and unexpected, except this time she gets to be a little bit closer without worrying. Adora’s not sure that’s exactly a good thing.



Catra is running at a thousand watts. She's certain this is what execution vis-à-vis an electric chair would feel like. One impulsive decision led to another and now she's standing in line to enter a fake coal mine with a gal who has impossibly broad shoulders, legs for days and the prettiest blue eyes she's ever seen. And that laugh, a sound she would like to bottle up and hang from a star to gaze up at as the train rumbles over the tracks beneath her. Who needs blankets when that laugh seeps warmth all the way down to the tips of her toes?

Lighting bugs are dancing in her stomach, all warm and fluttery as the guide talks about the future plans for the museum, and thanking them for coming to their one, and only exhibit. A few women have caught her eye before, but not even the stolen kisses in alleys can compare to the way this perfect stranger has her nerves alight.

Catra can barely process what the guide is saying as they step onto the lift. It's completely dark, and people are whispering around them but the only thing she is thinking about is where their elbows meet, tucked into eachother, arm in arm, how warm she is. They are packed in like sardines, Catra disseminates through her buzzing thoughts that the guide mentions this as accurate representation too. Something like this would usually put her on edge, and she is, just not in her usual way. Packed together in total darkness with strangers, but that arm in hers is an anchor of possibility.

The lift stops, and a dim light has creeped in just enough to see that they've been staring at each other, unwittingly in the total darkness. Catra's nose is just a hair away from Adora's who's looking down at her. She doesn't have time for brain to catch up

to her thudding heart's panic because the crowd presses them forward, following the guide who's now lit a head torch to supplement the lamps.

Catra's never been in a coal mine, and she's pretty sure Adora hasn't either, based on the heavy Chi-town lilting in her words. It feels real, aside from the lack of heat the guide tells them about. Catra's not so sure with how flushed she feels.

It's hard to focus on the words, on the way ahead and it seems she's not the only one. Catra keeps looking toward Adora only to find her head already turned toward hers. They manage to make conversation though, asking curious questions to each other about each doodad and gadget they pass by.

There's one part where they are offered a go at the pickaxe, to swing it into the wall, or to use the hammer and wedge to split a stone. People don't use the same rather dangerous pattern the actual miners use and demonstrate, lest someone lose a finger but they line up all the same.

Adora trods up excitedly and reaches for the hammer. Based on what Catra's already felt of this woman's arms, she's more than ready to watch this. The man holds the sledgehammer out to Adora with a warning about how heavy it is, and not to hurt herself. Catra thinks for a second she might need to drag her away before Adora starts what's probably the first fist fight in this museum, but then she smirks, and hoists the hammer easily.

Adora is plenty rugged, dress or no, Catra has definitely noticed, but her eyes bulge as Adora swings the hammer to the wedge. With a loud crack the stone splits and the miners and fellow tour goers stare at her, wide eyed. Catra shifts more uncomfortably than the men in the room look, trying to control the sudden and unexpected wetness between her legs.

"Easy." Adora says sweetly and sets the tool down at the man's feet. Thankfully, Adora doesn't go for the pickaxes, Catra doesn't think could take that without sweeping Adora right off her get

away sticks and find a private corner. Behind a prop maybe? Catra shakes her head. No… Maybe?

Her growl to prowl is thankfully tampered by the time they reach the tail end of the tour. Catra melts at Adora's heartbroken expression when they get to the canary, singing beautifully in its iron cage. It's job is to sing and breathe, and when it stops both it acts as a warning to the miners to evacuate as soon as possible. This one doesn't live down here always as the ones of the mine do, but that doesn't cease Adora's sollem face.

"You alright?" Catra whispers, squeezing Adora's fingers and blue eyes meet hers. She's smiling but there's something deeper behind her gaze that makes Catra have to steel herself. She really wants to kiss her right now, like there's a vice on her heart and the only release is the lever of Adora's lips, but she doesn't because she's only just met this woman and is feeling loose in her screws.

"Yeah." Adora says in a reluctant tone, and looks back grimly at the bird singing dutifully. "I just know how it must feel."

At that moment, Catra has twin thoughts. She would die for Adora. She is also, impossibilly, inexplicably, in love with her, this beautiful stranger.

Arson, Alligators and Picture Palaces

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The light of day isn’t as blinding as it should be, not when Adora has someone so pretty to look at. The Museum of Science and Industry wasn't much, but the simulated coal mine was interesting, and it’s exciting on its own to experience something so new, so unnecessary. She can’t remember the last time she spent a cent that wasn’t budgeted for.

The sun’s still far from touching the horizon and they still have money to spend. Adora slides her hand down the sleeve of Catra’s shirt until she feels the warmth of her palm. Catra finishes the impulse for her, fingers intertwining.

“So that was neat, huh?” Adora says, wishing she could come with anything better to say, but her stomach feels like someone’s making flapjacks in there.

“Yup.” Catra replies with a nervous swallow of her own. They stand there, and it’s probably only a few seconds of silence but feels much, much longer.

“So…” Adora says again, shuffling her feet aimlessly, as if she's suddenly transported back to her teen years, fumbling for words after her first kiss.

“So…” Catra repeats, looking just as lost. At that, they make eye contact again and both start laughing at how ridiculous they are being. It’s weird for Adora, to be like this in public, but Catra’s mirrored state of amour eases her enough to stand tall again.

“Want to walk along the beach? See what we can get up to there? There’s always something happening around the lake.”

“Yeah, that sounds nice.”

It doesn’t take long for them to make the short journey, even at the meandering pace they set. Catra looks surprised at Adora’s guess she’s from Georgia. She explains that one of her housemates is from there, Perfuma. Catra fills her in on what it was like growing up there, and is slightly intimidated by how excited Adora gets about the gators, and informs her that no, wanting to wrestle them isn’t a normal response to those overgrown iguanas.

Adora listens raptly to Catra’s tales of train travel, all the places she’s been so far, all the different foods and people she’s met along the way. Adora’s never left Chicago and seeing all of America’s wonders through Catra’s eyes is sparking something inside her.

They get to talking about how Catra started her journey, and in this they unfortunately have something in common. Catra left to relieve the burden on her extended family, as well as feeding her wanderlust. Her Aunt and Uncle had been housing her since the flu took Catra’s parents, and there wasn’t work to be had.

Adora lost her mother from the flu too, her father years before during The Great War. Her only memories of him are of his two shore leaves before the letter and flag arrived at their doorstep. The way her mother talked though, as Adora held onto her mother’s factory uniform as she worked, you’d think he’d could’ve defeated the Germans single handedly.

After the factory hired returning soldiers, Adora’s mother started her job with the Queens, where Adora stays now. After the flu took Mara, Angella and Micha took Adora in, right along with other wayward souls that came in need. Adora knows she’s lucky, but she also understands the feeling of being a burden all too well. After having to downsize to the apartment over the store, it’s getting a bit tight, and a lot harder to feed everyone.

“Eight people is quite the cramp.” Catra agrees, and suddenly Adora feels foolish for bringing it up at all, given that she has a roof over her head every night, but Catra doesn’t seem to mind, in

fact she shudders. “I like sleeping in the box cars. We usually all take one as a group, but sometimes we get to spread out, for privacy.” Catra winks at her. “It depends on the conductor but we don’t usually have to scurry out like roaches when the train starts to slow. As long as the cargo doesn’t go missing, they don’t really care. It’s neat, waking up someplace new everyday. I don’t think I could do what you’re doing. I’d always be bein’ evil if I was that close with Kyle every day.”

“Well, it’s nice that we each sort of get our own room, even if mine used to be the garden closet, nicest room in my opinion, it’s away from everyone else when the uh… other business isn’t open. It is why I go out most days though. My room is too small for me to hole up there all day. Winter is the worst, we all share the living room to keep warm. Glimmer and Hawk snore, back and forth even, like a damn saw.”

It occurs to Adora that she’s never gotten to tell anyone about her makeshift family before. Every face safe enough to tell to already knows them all when they come in to drink and dance in the “Brightmoon Ballroom.” The “proper” customer’s of Lavender and Lye just want their laundry. People too rich or important enough to do their own, and the folks that use the self wash are too busy getting by to be bothered.

But, Catra is more than happy to listen. They trade stories of their queer families like they’re old friends finally getting a chance to bump gums again. The other people on the beach might as well not exist for all Adora cares. She’s with Catra, whose nose crinkles as cute as a bug’s ear when she smiles, whose inflection has Adora on the tip of her toes for the very next word.

Catra is pulled from their mutual revere first, looking away from the waters and toward the city. Adora follows her gaze to a little park side store where people are dancing. Familiar notes hit Adora’s ears and she doesn’t even second guess herself. Catra is the one trying to keep up this time as Adora steams on ahead.

She stops a ways away from the crowd and spins around. Catra is already ready for her, their still joined hands aloft and her other is held out and waiting for Adora's waist.

The excited instruments fade back into the radio, and everyone looks toward the receiver, waiting to hear what the host graces them with next.

"And that was Kansas City Shuffle by Bennie Morton. I don't know how they do it there, but I'm sure they got nothin' on our Chicago shufflers. Alright folks, We've got live music coming in here soon but for now, why don't you show off your sweetheart, sweep her off her feet with Gene Austin's, Ain't she sweet."

If they were back at the bar, Adora would do just that, but for now she'll take pushing up close, her chin to Catra's cheek as they step to the music. Adora has done more than just cast an eye, as Mr. Austin is suggesting. Catra feels so good, so perfect in her arms, like they were made to hold on to her as they dance. Maybe it's the disguise easing her mind, but Adora has never felt this comfortable and excited with someone before. It's like a puzzle that's practically putting itself together and she desperately wants to finish making the pretty picture. Adora wants so badly to see if Catra's lips are as sweet and warm as she feels beneath her hands.

"You like this music but are you a…" Catra trails off and chews her lip. "I was gonna say cat, but since you're so obsessed with them, I think the men's version, alligator, suits you better."

Adora chortles and turns her head so Catra can get a good look. "Does it look like my ears are made of tin? Of course I like swing. I prefer leading though, tossing gals in the air, all that jazz."

"Well, if we weren't here…" Catra says with a blush. Adora isn't quite done turning her into a beet yet.

"Are you sure you don't want to wrestle an alligator?"

Catra is rendered speechless, and hides her face by ducking down until her forehead is pressed against Adora's nose. "Shush, you."

They don't part as the music stops, dancing to a tune of their own as the host introduces the next song. This one is even more perfect, but the words also make Adora laugh. "What's so funny, doll?" Catra asks with an amused whisper. "Am I stepping on your toes?"

"Not at all, kitten." Catra's called her doll enough times for Adora to throw out a rather apt pet name of her own. She slides one hand down to the small of Catra's back and lifts her a little. Catra's on the tips of her toes now and pulls her head back just long enough to shoot Adora a confused look that makes it even harder for Adora to keep her laughter down.

"There we go." Adora says once her humor dies to a hum. "Need a few more inches, now we're 'dancing cheek to cheek'." It takes a second, but Adora can feel a smile grow wider now that it's pressed up against hers.

"You ass."

"So vulgar, Catra. And here I was thinking you were some sort of clean southern bell."

Catra strangles back her own laugh at that. They aren't even dancing anymore, just hanging off each other as Catra tucks further into Adora's shoulder for continued quiet conversation. "Oh, you haven't seen vulgar from me yet, darling."

Adora presses her lips against Catra's ear and she can feel her body tense along with a quiet gasp when Adora squeezes her hip. "Is that a promise?" Adora pulls back, full of herself and basking in the glow of the heat once again creeping down Catra's neck.

They stay dancing for a few more songs, enjoying the excuse to be so close. It's not overly forward to run a hand down the length of an arm or press your hips together when the big band calls you to. Eventually though, they both fall prey to the smell of fresh

baked pretzels wafting from the shop the crowd's been dancing to the radio of.

The strange pressure that's been there since Adora locked eyes with this roguish woman has transformed into a sharp tension between them. Adora can't decide if she's the hare hiding in the bush, or the fox waiting for the right opportunity. By the way they eat quietly, and the want in Catra's eyes, it's clear that she's feeling it too.

A cool, gentle breeze off of the lake wraps around them as they stand shoulder to shoulder against the side of the building. Adora doesn't really want to say anything. There's a fire blazing between them but there's also this moment that feels so rich in its simplicity. It's just her and her date, looking out at the water as they eat. She doesn't want to break it because as Catra said, she's leaving, and this feels like something Adora could be content doing every day.

She's pulled from her thoughts when Catra flicks the salt off of her fingers and reaches into her pocket, producing a cigarette case and pulls one out.

"Share a snipe with me?"

Adora nods and takes the cigarette, Catra lights it for her. She only takes a few puffs, they aren't her favorite thing but after the rich, buttery bread she isn't used to, she'll take all the help she can get. It's totally worth it too, the way Catra eyes the cork before bringing it to her own lips once she passes it back. Almost a kiss.

"I've got probably two hours left, sun sets around eight I think. As long as I'm back before then, I'm all yours."

"I'm sure we'll think of something to do." Adora replies. Somewhere private, hopefully. If they take a cab, she could always take Catra home, and they have some change left.

Catra's smile is nothing if not mischievous, and she gives Adora's hand a squeeze. They pass the snipe back and forth a few times, Catra has it with a just a few puffs left, and Adora would really like to feel the indirect warmth of her lips again to hold her over for a hopeful later.

"Can I have the last pull?"

"Sure thing." Catra moves to put it between her fingers and stops, smirking. Instead the cork gets tucked into her lip as she opens her mouth wide and flips it before trapping the still lit cigarette inside her mouth.

Adora barks out a surprised laugh, and Catra is obviously trying not to giggle through her smug, cheeky smile. Adora's the fox, she decides. She cups the side of Catra's face, steps in close and plants one on her. Catra's lips are soft and fit Adora's perfectly. It's just a peck with a little extra pressure so she can truly feel the curve of her lips. Catra's face laxes under Adora's hand and she pulls back. Once her eyes open again she sees Catra looking at her with a mix of shock and longing. At least Adora hopes it's longing. She's about to apologize as Catra inhales sharply through her nose and steps forward, stops suddenly, and doubles over.

Adora's not sure what to do as Catra hacks, the somehow not soggy cigarette falling to the ground and rolling away with the breeze.

"Oh my gosh, are you okay!?" Adora rubs Catra's shoulder as she gasps for air. Well done Adora, kiss a girl and nearly kill her.

Catra looks up at her, hands gripping her knees and eyes watering. "I'm fine." she says hoarsely and rights herself, not looking fine at all. Catra holds up a finger and stumbles over to a nearby drinking fountain.

Adora is still grimacing when Catra shuffles back, looking thoroughly sorry, she hopes. Catra steps square to her, hands in

her pockets and looks around. Adora does too, worried now that she caused a scene.

No one is peering down the side of the shop, the people she can see are still dancing, arms wrapped around each other, looking lost in love. When she turns back around, Catra has the olive cap in her hand, and she's running the other through short back curls.

Being able to see more of her, see how clever this cut is, from bob to unbelievably sexy slicked back hair, just cements what an unbelievable beauty Adora's spending the day with. Curly strands frame her sharp features so nicely and oh, how long those lashes are.

"Umm, Adora, could we try that ag-"

She's already kissing her, and this time Catra is kissing her back instantly with fervor. This is no sweet polite peck, it's an explosion of that building pressure that started hours ago. The tension of the string snapped and she can't uncoil it. Adora stops pushing forward only once a wall is met. Catra has her hands firmly in Adora's hair, pulling the back of her head for more. She'll give it, gladly.

Catra's teeth are sharp against her lips, and her gasps are as sweet as sarsaparilla. Adora braces one hand on the wood wall and pulls back, both of them breathing hard and Catra is looking at her with such obscene intensity her heart seizes. She wants this more than she's ever wanted anything. She wants a little love nest to wake up in every day next to her, looking at her like that. This is so much more than a kiss, it's an inspiration. She barely… no, Adora knows her, the important parts anyway, the things you feel in your bones. That's the reason she wants to kiss her like she's building a future. Adora's lips are acting like they want to be perpetually, life long roommates with Catra. Maybe, just maybe, Catra's are too.

Her hand trails down the side of Adora's face, thumb grazing over lip before pulling her in for another kiss. That's not all though, she happily tips closer when one of Catra's legs hooks her in. Adora presses a hand on the back of her lifted thigh, letting it trail higher and higher, feeling the give of soft flesh under the linen. She needs to feel more of… There's shouting.

They both whip their heads around to see flames licking up the sides of the newspaper stand, and one spent cigarette butt rocking back and forth in the breeze against the side. A man rounds the corner with a bucket, the same one who sold them the pretzel, and dumps water over the stack of print.

Adora didn't just cause a scene, she started a damned fire because she was too gay to wait. If they get caught, what would the papers even call this accidental arson? She can see the headline now as the shopkeep locks eyes with her and her mussed hair, Catra pinned against the wall with her body and her guilty eyes over the now smoldering fire. ***Beloved park side store nearly destroyed by the "Flaming Homosexual."***

The shopkeep's face is on its way to purple with anger, and she feels Catra let out a shaking breath. "Make tracks?" Catra squeaks. Adora doesn't even answer, grabbing Catra by the hand and yelling "I'm so sorry!" as they run back towards the anonymity of the city streets.

It's unlikely that anyone's chasing them but Adora keeps going anyway. She eventually dropped Catra's hand, but she's still right beside her, and grinning from ear to ear. Adora realizes she is too. This side of town is more crowded on the sidewalks than on their first escape. A few people gasp and leap out of the way. Adora hears a "Well I never." and "Young people these days." once or twice, but they keep running.

Once the laughter is taking up too much room in their lungs to keep her legs pumping she pads to a stop, immediately collapsing against the brick wall of an unsuspecting building. At least brick isn't so flammable. "You know-" Catra pants as she shakes her hat

back into form. “I think- that Lonnie’s-” she takes another deep breath, “ Lonnie’s right. I’m - trouble on-“

“Two feet.” Adora finishes for her, and pulls Catra by the arm to brace against the wall with her. “Very sexy trouble.” Adora adds with a wink, and they’re both laughing again.

Eventually they manage to catch enough air to regain wit enough for Catra to step off the wall. “Where in blazes are we?”

Adora points across the street, to the marquee’s up down the block. “Theater street, apparently, and maybe don’t say blazes?” Catra rolls her eyes and pops her cap back on. Adora joins her back in the land of the upright and follows Catra’s eyes as they take in the various signs. A few places are for live entertainment, others are picture palaces. The biggest lines are outside of some of the surefire hits she’s seen billboard’s for like *King Kong* . Others are showing older films, probably hoping those who can't get in to see the latest and greatest will still still want to make something of their evening.

She can see where Catra’s mind is going. She looks toward the dipping sun in the sky, still up there but not nearly as high as Adora would like. She then looks toward one of the less ritzy picture palaces and pulls the last of their shared change out of her pocket. “Yes.” Adora says before Catra can even form the words. She doesn’t even care what movie, as long as it isn’t a new one, or gory.

They end up in front of one of the few movie’s Adora’s seen before. John Wayne’s *Ride Him, Cowboy* . Catra raises her brows at the title and lets out a low whistle. It should be a gay test really because the only people who give Adora that reaction when she talks about it are other fanciers of the same sex. “It’s not that, you egg. It’s about a horse on trial for murder.” Catra’s eyebrows go even higher. It stings just a little. “Are we actually watching it or…?” Adora asks softly. That’s where she thought Catra was going with this, finding someplace dark, private. They could go to her

room still, but unless the cabbie guns it and can slip through traffic, sunset wouldn't be far behind.

"Right! Right. You betcha, I mean…" Catra clears her throat and approaches the ticket master with the last of their coin. The movie had already started, so they didn't even need to ask the usher for a seat in the back. It's unusual to see a picture palace this empty from what Adora's been told. She's only been a few times and all those were filled to the brim, but there were also a lot less options then. This one looks more like a family owned business. She can't bring herself to feel too bad about it though when Catra turns in her seat, cap held nervously in her hands.

Adora brushes her fingers through Catra's hair, the wild, woody scent of her pomade is temptation enough to pull Adora closer. She presses a kiss to Catra's cheek and they both sigh. This, this all she wants to do, give and get whatever Catra's comfortable with. They don't have long, and it's not under the best circumstances, but they only have an hour or so left. Adora pushes that thought behind her. This feeling isn't fading. The feeling that Catra is unlike anyone she's ever kissed before. This feeling is somehow, made in the span of a day, maybe even the moment their eyes met, is love. Adora is going to make this hour count. It's now or never, and she'd rather have now. The never again, well, that's a problem for future Adora.

Every point of contact, bump of their knees, Catra's fingers curled over Adora's shoulder, the tap of her temple and press of cheeks together seems more precocious and sensual than any of the times Adora's spent naked and pressed against another woman. The few patrons, and the glow of the film itself feel so far away as she presses another kiss to Catra's cheek, and then another just below her ear. The only sound Adora can hear is the shaky breath that's coming quicker against her neck. She's sure no matter where they were right now, they'd still be alone, together, at the edge of their own little borrowed universe.

Adora trails kisses lazily, hand pressing against the loose fabric just below Catra's sternum until she feels the solid body

underneath. Catra mirrors her, dropping the hat into her lap and pressing her hand into Adora's stomach. Adora leans further into the other seat, kissing her hairline, taking in the scent of her that's beneath pomade. Catra's breath is getting more raged, and suddenly the waist of Adora's dress is being pulled taught. She leans away just enough to glance down to see Catra's fist clenched tight around the fabric.

"Hey, are you alright?" Adora asks quietly and draws back until she can take in all of Catra's face.

Catra clears her throat and nods, her deep, deliberate breath indicating otherwise.

"I can stop, we can just sit here. All I want is to be here, with you. Okay?"

Catra turns away and sighs before facing back again. "No, it's not that. I've…I've…never." She stops and buries her head into Adora's shoulder.

Adora hasn't in a place like this before either. There was a silent rondevu in a dressing room last year, but at least then there had been walls and a curtain. This feels plenty private though, thoroughly dark and no one has reason to look back. If they did, all they would see is the fight glow of the screen reflecting off of two kissing faces, not unusual. There isn't any better options. "It is risky here, but I think it'll be okay. It's dark. Again, Catra, we don't need to-"

"I want to!" Catra rushes out as she jerks her head up, getting lue of shushes. Adora glares at the silhouettes of the handful of people near the front. "I want to..." Catra says hushed this time. "Can we just… Can I kiss you for a bit first?" Her sharp features look so soft now, even in the dim light those dazzling gold and blue eyes are so full of tenderness and want.

"The answer to that will never be no."

Catra cups her face and leads the kiss this time. It's more gingerly than before, curious and exploratory, like she's trying to map the shape of Adora's lips. Catra is the great adventurer, her kisses and touches are keen to draw out any hidden treasures to take for keepsakes. Adora guides her with heavy sighs to find them. She uses her teeth in tentative nips and tugs that has Adroa's pulse racing. Her tongue, oh god, Catra's tongue. When it brushes Adora's she has to swallow back a moan so sinful it would absolutely give them away.

Adora keeps her hands in polite places but its getting harder to hold them down. She feels like a coiled spring and Catra's sweet touch is winding it tighter and tighter. It's only when Catra's hand lands on top of hers does she realize Adora's been gripping the top of Catra's leg like vice. She relaxes her fingers and Catra guides her hand up and down her leg.

"Touch me."

So she does. Adora roams up and down and to the both sides of her thigh.She can feel the taught muscle on top, but the sides are soft and Adora wishes she could feel them for real, drag her nails over the skin there. She imagines the pillowy insides of her thighs muffling all sounds except their heartbeats as Adora makes a home between her legs. With the arm she has tucked awkwardly between them, Adora brings her hand up to one of Catra's buttons, then another before slipping inside. Catra's skin is hot beneath her palm. Here Adora takes some indulgence, tracing the feel of her ribs, the texture of her skin and Catra is gasping into her mouth. Adora isn't faring much better. Her brows are pinched so tight she almost can't open her eyes when Catra's lips move down to her neck, still full of soft nips and a building sense of urgency.

The back of her dress is damp with sweat but that has nothing on how completely ruined her underwear are. Catra's tucked her hand under the top of Adora's dress and finally she grabs a handful. Adora searches for and captures her lips quickly to mute the moan they both start too loudly.

She slides her hand up further on the inside of Catra's thigh wanting to drink another in and she gets her wish along with a quiet "Fuck." when Catra bucks into her hand.

"Do you want-"

"Yes. Fuck. Yes, Adora."

"Can I hold you?"

Catra's wobbling as she pulls herself up out of the seat, and Adora scoots back. She situaties her dress high up on her waist so Catra can sit comfortably between. Once she's seated, Catra falls back against her. Adora immediately makes work of pressing reassuring kisses up and down her neck and cheek, reveling in the salty sweetness of her skin.

It's like Catra is trying to occupy the same space as her with how hard she's pressing against her, and Adora wishes she could. She wraps one arm across Catra's chest and squeezes her tight while her free hand untucks her shirt. In other circumstances, Adora would spend hours kissing her there too. Instead she makes small circles over Catra's stomach.

She can't see much of her like this when they are so close, but she can see Catra looking from the corner of her eye. If Adora thought Catra looked obscene before, the way she's looking at Adora now beneath heavy lids is straight up pornopghrapic. Gorgeous. Adora's never actually felt a wave of lust wash over her before and as turned on as she is already it shouldn't be possible.

"You are so beautiful." Adora is caught off guard by how husky her voice sounds.

"You're one to talk." Catra huffs, sounding almost mad about it and Adora has to laugh into her neck. Catra arches up, shaking hands fumbling with hooks of her waistband and that douses the laughter efficiently. Adora goes back to kissing her neck and Catra melts into her again. She takes her time, continuing the adoring touch on Catra's stomach. She drags her fingernails lightly up and

down her skin, mesmerized by the way Catra fights to keep from shuddering. Adora feels every twitch and once Catra is rocking her hips in desperation she makes her way to soft, sticky curls.

Catra is so wet and gasping so loud that Adora has to cover her mouth before she's even really touched her. Adora finally finds her in the all the slick and Catra slaps her own hand over Adora's, pushing it tighter against her mouth to muffle the string of cries she can't hold back. The hot breath against her hand is by far the most holy thing Adora has ever experienced. "How are you real?" Adora whispers and she's not even sure what she's saying, or why. "What did I do to deserve to meet you?" It's a genuine question, impossible for her to conceive how this perfect woman ended up in her lap, writhing. She draws slow circles around Catra's clit almost mindlessly, like its a thing she's done a thousand times before and she's never ever going to forget how or how special it feels to make Catra shake like this. "You are so, so beau-" Adora is cut short by teeth digging into her palm and Catra curling into herself.

Adora drops her hand away from Catra's mouth once the vibration of her moan fades so she can catch her breath. Adora returns to holding her tight with plenty of kisses to the side of her face and neck again. She knows her face is going to be sticky with pomade but she can't help herself, nuzzling into Catra's hair and just breathing in time with her heaving chest.

She stills her fingers that had kept going lazily as Catra worked through it. It happened so fast and intensely that she's sure Catra is probably extremely sensitive right now. But when Adora starts to move back up, Catra's hips rise to follow.

"Don't stop. Please." The desperation in Catra's voice is nearly drowned out by the pounding of Adora's own heart in her ears. She shifts to the side and Catra picks up quickly where Adora's going with this. The awkward twist of their bodies in the cramped space is uncomfortable but Adora needs to kiss her properly, and Catra seems to need that too.

The arm of the seat is digging into her side but all Adora cares about is the tongue, teeth, hot air between them and the searing heat beneath her finger tips. Adora wants to do this everyday, make a mess of this woman's curls as Catra desperately pulls at the hair on the crown of own head. It's so hard to be quiet, painful even to stop the moans from escaping her throat. Even though the hand between Catra's legs lack the frantic desperation the rest of her body is displaying, it doesn't take long before Catra's legs are clenching tight again.

Adora pulls back from the wild rush of kisses and watches her face , changing light from the projection across the room dancing over her parted, kiss swollen lips. "Look at me." Adora whispers and Catra wrenches her eyes open. She looks like she's in blissful agony, and it's the most precious thing Adora's ever seen. No painting or sculpture could ever compare to the hazey, lost, desperate look under those sweat drenched, pinched brows. "Don't stop looking at me." *Please,* never stop the way you look at me.

Catra does her best but ultimately has to concede to instinct as Adora draws out her second orgasam. She sets Catra free from trying to follow Adora's greedy demand by kissing her through the rest of it. Catra's fist is balled up in Adora's dress again and locking her in place. She's not going anywhere, even if Catra wasn't holding onto her so tight.

Adora wipes her fingers off fruitlessly against Catra's thigh, conceding to use the fabric on the underside of her dress instead before fastening Catra's pants back up. The gorgeous girl with a roguish smile and handsome dark curly hair is a sweaty, sleepy puddle against Adora's chest and she's taking advantage of it while she can.

Catra is nuzzled into her neck, still catching her breath and leaving butterfly soft kisses as Adora pets her head. They stay like that through the rest of the movie. Adora's wetter than she's ever been in her life but that pales in comparison clench in her chest when she looks down at Catra tucked up under her chin.

They both groan when the lights start to grow in the room, but Catra finds her feet quickly. Adora doesn't want to get up, to leave, to say goodbye. Catra pops her cap back on and looks down at Adora with a hard set in her jaw. Adora doesn't know what to make of that look, doesn't want to know what it means because it seems angry, confused.

Catra stretches a hand out to her. "Come on." Her words are choked but not as venomous as her demeanor would imply.

Adora follows her back outside, and once her eyes adjust she see's Catra glaring at the beautiful watercolors that mark the beginning of sunset. They walk with purpose until Catra spots an empty alleyway and squares up to Adora.

She braces herself, preparing for the pain she passed off to not so distant after all truth she'd set aside for future Adora. She'd hoped for at least a few hours before the "never again" began to sink in. Catra swallows visibly and stares at Adora with hard set eyes. She's also nervous about how Catra's acting. She's gone from looking up at Adora adoringly through her long lashes, whispering sweet nothings into skin between exhausted kisses and exploratory touches, to this.

"Do you know anyone that can take in five people for the night?" Catra asks sternly with a slight tremble in there. "Anyone safe? Our host cant keep us any longer."

The tension in Adora's shoulders lax and now she sees what this is from Catra. She's trying not to cry, and now Adora's suddenly fighting back the urge too. Adora closes the distance and wraps her arms around Catra, cradling the back of her head as feels Catra's jaw clench tighter against Adora's shoulder. Catra is hugging her back though, squeezing her so tight Adora can barely move.

"You can stay with us, at Lavender and Lye." Adora says with disbelief, with relief.

“You already have eight people there Adora, we couldn’t-”

“There’s room, Catra, if you all don’t mind sleeping in the bar, after we wrap up.”

Catra sniffles and laughs. “Are you serious right now?” She turns away, blinking back leaky faucets. “You run a clip joint?”

Adora grins at the humor in her tone before kissing the side of her face. She rubs her hand along Catra’s back to soothe her as she fills in the blanks. “A homosexual clip joint, but I don’t run it. I am the barkeep tonight though. First round’s on the house, if you want to stay. You’d all have to come dressed *propper* for safety reasons, but you can change when you get there. Plus it's a laundry service so it won't look weird if you carry them in.”

“You are impossible.” Catra says turning back to her. She kisses Adora long, and slow. It would be one hell of a farewell, but it’s not, this time anyway, and that’s even better. It’s at least another five more minutes before Adora can tell her the address and code if Micha isn’t at the desk. Despite Catra’s protests, she takes the dollar bill she’d given Adora earlier in the day and hails down a cab. Catra blows her a kiss from the window of the car as it drives off and future Adora holds onto it, her problems put off for a little bit longer.

Chapter End Notes

This felt so tender to write, I embarrassed myself.

So my favorite jokes in this, are the not joke, jokes. Flaming homosexual wasn't used until the 1970's, and I think I'm clever.

Next chapter should be up by the 23rd. (And the fourth and hopefully final chapter up within a week of then.)

To Be Known (Too Damn Well)

Chapter Notes

breathes in possibly increasing the chapter count again*

I ended up cutting this chapter here, and saving what I had planned for this one for what's hopefully going to be the last chapter. I just felt like this one came to a nice little circle and having everything else would just be too much all at once since I want to linger on the fun goings on coming up.

I don't know what to title this chapter, so It might change if I think of something better.

Some pre chapter slang knowledge. A tomato is a very crass/lewd thing to call a woman.

(She’s ripe for the picking)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora’s very much in a daze when she makes it to the doors of Lavender and Lye. It’s amazing she made it here at all after getting on the wrong streetcar, twice.

She couldn’t stop thinking about it all, about her. Today was supposed to be just like every other. She would look for work, fail because most places (all places) were only hiring men, maybe stop by the market and sweet talk a chump for an orange, come back to the Lye empty handed, tend bar and do it all over again tomorrow. Instead she was missing someone who she’s known for less than 24 hours, daydreaming about kissing her again, and thinking about how she’s just going to have to say goodbye tomorrow. She doesn’t want to say goodbye, but she also can’t imagine walking through these doors again alone. Adora steals

herself, shaking out her limbs and taking a few deep breaths. She needs to get it together.

"Welcome to Lav- Oh, it's you. You're late." Mermista says with a pop of her gum. She looks as bored as usual and as bothered to be interrupted in her reading, but then she narrows her eyes at Adora. "You're never late." Adora blinks at her, not exactly sure where to start. She could protest that she's not *really* late, people don't start coming in for at least another 30 but Adora usually helps haul the latest batch behind the bar for consumption. Mermista sets her book down and leans towards her on the counter. "You also look like that time Hawk drilled you in the head with a baseball. Fess up, buttercup."

Adora takes a deep breath and puts her mitts on the counter, staring down at the chipped wood instead of Mermista. "Well…" It's not even possible to explain Catra to her before she has to go down stairs, especially not with these world tilting feelings boiling up inside her. Maybe instead she could summarize the events of her day? "I helped steal cash from a handsy hotdog man, visited a coal mine, spent some time on the beach, almost burnt down that one parkside shop, the one where you got that big shade umbrella, and then I made love in a theater." There's a beat of silence and without looking up Adora raises her hand for the high five that follows in lue of a punch on the shoulder. "I think…" She starts and feels dizzy, silly at the prospect of admitting it out loud. "I'm in love."

"I did not hear a word of this." Micah calls out from the stairs to the apartment, finally getting Adora to lift her eyes from the counter top. "Except for that last part. Good for you, sweetheart. What's the lucky lady's name? Do we know her?" Micha strides up next to Mermista and has to shoo her away for once. Usually Mermista scoots before her relief even has a chance to say hello. She doesn't leave though, just slides further down the counter and looks at Adora, amused.

"Catra, and no, she's just been in town for a few days." Adora says, an unstoppable smile forming on her lips. "She's coming

tonight.”

“I’ll say.” Mermista snarks. Adora tries to ignore her, the tips of her ears burning. It's one thing to talk about that with friends, it’s quite another to talk about it in front of the man who’s basically become her fill in father.

“She’s bringing other people with her, four I think. I thought it might be okay if they slept downstairs tonight, after everyone’s gone home.”

“Well, we know one of them isn’t staying there all night…”

Mermista is lucky that the service bell is screwed to the counter, but her book isn’t. “Merms!” Adora chucks her latest mystery novel at her but she catches it easily.

“Times are changing. Some may keep it hush hush still, but you know Angella and I have a-“

“Stop, please, please don’t finish that sentence, Micah.” Adora glares at Mermista who’s making bedroom eyes and bouncing her brows. “Is it alright if they stay?” Adora says, thoroughly exasperated and ready to get away from these two as quickly as possible.

“Of course, Adora. I’ll call upstairs to make sure we have enough food for them tonight.” Micah says before leaning in closer. Adora holds her breath, hoping this isn’t about to me more awkward sex talk with him. “I can’t wait to meet her.”

Her grin is back, she can’t help it, until Mermista nudges her on the shoulder and holds two fingers up in a V shape. Adora gooses her on the side before she can stick her tongue out and trods to the back.

Just where she knew to find her, Entrapta is elbows deep in her contraption that she swears up and down will change the laundry business forever. No more pre soaks, scrubbing and pruney fingers. The dream, almost good to be true.

“Hey, how’s your doodad going?”

Entrapta pops her head out from the basin and holds her hand out to Adora expectantly. Adora looks around for whatever tool she can hand her but there's nothing but clothes. Adora picks up a pair of pants and a shirt, silently praying that these are abandoned clothes and not a customer’s.

The grease painted, wild, singed, pigtailed woman drops the garments inside with a splash. “I think I have it this time. I haven’t been electrocuted after the last two adjustments so we’ll see.” Entrapta says as she flips a switch on the machine. She doesn’t seem alarmed by the grinding so Adora quells her grimace.

“HEY, DID YOU HAPPEN TO SEE NET OR SPINNY ON YOUR WAY HERE TODAY?! DO YOU KNOW IF THEY’RE COMING TONIGHT?!”

“WHAT?!”

“DO YOU KNOW IF-” The basin rocks a few times and Adora takes a healthy step back. “NET AND-” The grinding gets louder before coming to a screeching halt. “Spinny are coming tonight?” The couple she *needs* to talk to about all this are Entrapta and Wally’s neighbors, so Adora is hoping that they had said something when Wally and Trap headed out this morning.

“Don’t they always on Saturday?” Entrapta asks, rather unperturbed by her invention's performance as she opens the lid. Yes, they are always here Saturday, first ones in, and the firsts ones out. Adora feels a little silly for even asking but she’s also anxious to see them.

The last time anything really changed here was three years ago when Seahawk and Mermista moved in, and even then the only real change in her routine each day was less to do. Hawk took over Ethnol (and the *accidental* , less potent, consumable, flavorful ethanol) production, and Mermista filled in most desk shifts. Glimmer and Bow always made quick of the stitch work,

even on days Bow worked at the cannery. Entrapta kept this place running, from the cabinet dryers to the electrical, and she also made the cleverest of hiding places for their growing variety of spirits Hawk was producing. Perfuma kept the Lavender a cut above the competition by her cheaply made added scents to the service when she wasn't working at the bank. All the going's around the property Adora has had a hand in at one point, so she knows it inside and out. Everyone in the Queen's kingdom had their place to keep this parcel a safe haven for them all, and well, now Adora had bartending once or twice a week, that role rotating between all of them for years. So yes, it was stupid to ask if they were coming. It's a Saturday.

"Yeah, I suppose so." Adora eventually says as Entrapta reaches into her machine. She produces two sopping wet, mangled and shredded pieces of fabric that vaguely resemble the clothes that went in there.

"I think I'm getting closer. I'm making fabric for patches anyway!"

"Trap, those are never picked ups, right?"

Entrapta looks at her rather curiously and tilts her head to the side. "Is that important?"

After getting a few articles of clothing safe for experimentation, Adora heads out the side door and to her room. Normally she dresses in no time flat, it's not like she has a *ton* of options. She could always raid the hangers for the Brightmoon guests to pick from but ends up going with her usual button up with a t-shirt underneath and suspenders. The only difference this time are neatly pressed dress pants that she's only worn at Mermista's and Hawk's in-home wedding reception.

Adora barely gets her pants fastened before hearing the anticipated footsteps on the gravel outside her door. "Come on in, Glimmer." She knew as the words flew out of mouth that Mermista would spread the word for her.

Her ornate sibling huffed as she shuffled into the small space. Adora takes herself in from themmirror hanging on her closet door as Glimmer finds her seat on the bed.

"So, is this a Starla thing or is it a real thing? I don't how it could be since you apparently-" Glimmer finally catches Adora's scowl in the mirror and frowns. "Look, I know you didn't mean to but that really hurt her, and you! You moped for weeks 'Dor. I don't want you to go through that again."

"I know that Glim." Adora says through her teeth. This outfit isn't right. "Jeeze, have some confidence in me at least, okay. You don't understand what it's like. I'm not forcing here." She glances back at Glimmer and relaxes a little now that she's looking adequately apologetic. "If anything I'm all wet about it, but I'm also excited? I don't know sis. It sounds nuts because I just met her, but…" Adora finishes with a shrug as she unbuttons her sleeves. The Starla thing stung but that's nothing new. She avoided coming in for a while because of Adora, but they are friends again at least. It still churns her stomach to see her sometimes. She didn't mean to lie to Starla, she *wanted* to love her.

"What do you mean I don't understand? Do you think I don't love Bow?" Glimmer asks, but at least it's genuine confusion and not laced with the previous accusatory tone.

"That's not what I mean at all." Adora says with a sigh that's both for the question and her rolled up sleeves. "You're lucky to have that with Bow. I know you like girls too but, you never had to- It's hard for me to meet people, Glim. I can't just out and say 'Hey, are ya gay? I think you're pretty."

"Yeah, I guess you're right. Sorry. But um, you really think you love her? Already?"

"I don't know, Glim. I think so though? How else could I describe it? I don't know her birthday, her favorite foods or anything but I feel like I *know* her." Adora half expected Glimmer to chime in

with a *"But that's stupid!"* or *"It's just a crush."* but instead she's sitting there, head in her hand waiting for Adora to go on. "Let see… she literally took my breath away when our eyes met. She makes me jittery and calm and nervous and confident. It's confusing. I tried not to think too much about, fuck, how special it felt because she was going to leave today and now she's not, but probably is tomorrow and… Fuck! I miss her! I've only met her today, it's been maybe an hour since I last saw her and I miss her! It felt weird coming home too. Like… she should be here if this is home." She ends her rant with her face in her hands, slumped over and seated next to Glimmer.

It isn't until Glimmer starts to rub her back that Adora comes out of hiding, peeping through her fingers. Her heart is beating a mile a minute at the prospect of seeing Catra again, at having to say goodbye and how impossible that feels to do. Adora clears her throat and takes a few calming breaths.

"But um, Catra, if Merms didn't gab her name also, she was telling me about how her and friends live, all the places she's been to. They all train hop, going from city to city. The most incredible thing though is that people like us can just… be? So it's not like I can ask her to give that up, stay with this person you just met." Adora shirks off the button up and stands to square up to mirror again. Just the shirt and suspenders look nice enough, causal and not looking like she's trying too hard. "Catra's friends, are in a three way relationship actually. Two guys and a gal. Can you believe it? No one bats an eye either. It's amazing." Adora spins to face Glimmer, and she almost looks a little distant, sad even. "And… uh they wouldn't if I dressed like this everyday either. Speaking of, how do I look?" It's the third rendition of this outfit, but she still isn't sure about it.

"You're smokin', Dor. Always are." Glimmer says fondly as she stands next to her. "I wish you could do that here too, you know?"

"Yeah, I know you do. I can when it's just us, or down in The Ballroom, at least." Adora says with a sideways glance. "And thanks. I don't know- I *do* know why I'm stressing out about,

well, everything. I just want to impress her. It's silly to be nervous all of a sudden, after the day we just had. God, Glim, I had so much fun today. I don't remember the last time I laughed this much. It's like I didn't know how boring I've been, not that I don't have fun with you all. Geeze, I'm sorry I just keep going on. Today was just so surprising for once. I didn't mean to pull your ear off with all this."

"It's okay." Glimmer lifts up to the tips of her toes and surprises Adora with a kiss on her cheek. Before Adora can ask what that was for, her hair tie is being pulled out. She tucks one side behind her ear and pats Adora on the shoulder before stepping toward the door. "There, I think that brings it together nicely. I'll see you down there later, Adora. Love you."

"Love you too…" Adora says back, a bit bemused as Glimmer shuts the door behind her.

She is greeted with wolf whistles as she reaches the bottom of the stairs. Net and Spinny are still going at it as Adora heads behind the bar. Her ears are hot and she's rolling her eyes, but she's so glad to see these two that she bites her tongue and pours the first three drinks for the night.

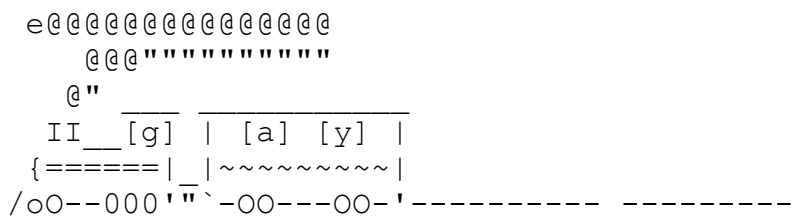
"Look at you! A tomato I'd say." Netossa says with a slap of her thigh. Adora's face is definitely going to catch fire. Spinnerella elbows her partner in the ribs and shakes her head, exasperated.

"Ignore her, but you do look nice, dear." Spinny says and then points at the three tumblers. "All dressed up and starting with us? What's loose, goose?"

Adora doesn't wait for them to pick up their glasses, she knocks hers back first to prepare for her question. Both the ladies' brows are raised high when she gently puts her glass in the sink. Adora braces hers against the bar and looks down at what she yearns to be her future. She's always thought that since they started coming in. This house has couples a plenty, but these two always felt like

a picture book dream. “How did… How did you both know? That, you know, ‘she’s the one.’”

Nettossa leans back on the barstool, a little taken aback and both her and Spinny turn to look at each other. Adora has to still her fingers from rapping against the wood as she waits. It’s Spinnerella who looks back at Adora first, and shrugs. “I think I knew immediately.”



Catra is buzzing like her shoes are full of bees as she makes her way to the freight zone. They agreed to meet here if they all couldn’t make it to the house first. She’s not sure what she’s going to do if they don’t agree to stay at least another night. It’s highly unlikely that they won’t. There’s been countless times that they’ve stayed places a day or two over what was planned, usually just because they could. Problem is that Catra usually bitches about it, on principle. The only time she didn’t was when they stayed in New York for three weeks straight. And that… was for a similar though far less intense reason.

If they do fight her, she won’t just leave them, but she also doesn’t want to not show up tonight as promised either. She can’t, *won’t* do that to Adora. Chicago was never her destination but she also feels sick at the thought of never seeing those beach blue eyes again.

“Hey, buddy!” Scorpia calls out, waving like she hasn’t seen her in days. She lifts up Catra’s battered suitcase in one hand and both

her own and Catra's bag in the other. "I grabbed your things! Do you have rocks in here or something? Sure is heavy."

"A brick actually, helps keep it from sliding around when we take corners. Hey, where's the trio? I need to talk to everyone."

"Oh, is everything okay? They're looking for a good car for us. Do I need to beat someone up?"

Before Catra could answer that no, no one needed a shiner, Kyle pokes his head out from a box far down the track and waves them down."No Scorp, I'll fill you in with everyone else."

The two of them gather their group's entire life stuffed in a few bags and cases and start the walk down. This train is fairly full of unauthorized riders, not unusual for the city stops. Most of them wave or give a friendly nod. Those that scowl or turn their nose, well they know that those aren't a part of their brother's and sisters.

"Took you long 'nuff." Lonnie says as Rogelio hops down to start loading their things. "Almost had to pack in with others."

"Actually, hold on a tick." Catra says and the three look at her curiously. She looks down at her feet, already nervously kicking the rocks. God, even Kyle's doe eyes feel heavy on her. "I was wondering if we could stay another day. Got a place for us, and we can have some fun too." Catra tilts an imaginary glass to her lips. They haven't had a run in with a cinder dick yet, but bringing a raid down on the lady you like isn't exactly romantic.

"Oooh! That sounds nice. I'm in!" Scorpia says with a slap to her back. Come on Scorp, spread that infectious enthusiasm and blind fellowship. Catra smiles at Ro and Lon hopefully. No dice.

"Aren't you always insisting we get back to San Fran this year as soon as possible?" Rogelio asks with a genuine perturbed grunt. Lonnie on the other hand starts off immediately suspicious.

“Yeah, Catra. You’re usually itching to leave, move on to the next adventure. What wedge are you chipping at this time?”

“No angle.” Catra says, crossing her arms nonchalantly. “Found a cool place is all.” They are obviously going to find out about Adora, but she isn’t going to pull that card out unless absolutely necessary, she’ll never hear the end of it and would rather show up in a good mood. Catra shrugs and Lonnie’s interrogatory face starts to turn into a smirk. Fuck. Catra stills her foot that was tapping against the rock like she might break it open and find gold there.

“You-” Catra can feel her ears start to burn. “met a girl, *didn’t you?”*

“No.” Catra says compulsively, but now her cheeks are hot and she knows her body has damn thrice betrayed her.

Lonnie starts laughing so hard that even the usually stone faced Rogelio quirks a lip.

“I think that’s great Ca-“

“Stuff it, Kyle.” Catra snaps but then throws him a sheepish “Thanks.”

“So, is this charm the hell out of, make out and run because you’re a scaredy-cat girl, or is this like the time you got all twisted in the sheets with that gangster's girlfriend?” Lonnie asks, way too fucking smugly.

“No, and no.” Catra snaps again. “And you know we didn’t, ya know-“

“Have sex?” Scorpia fills in, unhelpfully. Catra growls at her before staring back at her toes.

“So stop saying that. She nearly got me killed. But no it’s neither of those. I’m…” Catra squeezes her crossed arms tighter, glancing at each of her family members who for once in their lives are

showing a modicum of patience. “It’s more than that ever was. I’m… all dizzy about her.”

Scorpia’s coo isn’t enough to cover up Lonnie’s cackling, and she swears to God Rogelio laughed too. Catra tolerates this for about thirty seconds to long.

“So can we stay another night or not?”

“Fine, fine.” Lonnie huffs. “It’s probably too much to ask for a *please.* I’m also guessing she’s at this *cool place.* If everyone else is okay with it, let’s go meet your sweetie.”

Catra relaxes once everyone voices their agreement. With that finalized, she tosses a few of their bags onto the train and hops on after, which garners a bit of bafflement.

“We need to get changed first into um, *appropriate* clothing. We can fix up right once we’re there though.”

Lonnie groans as she hops back into the car she just got out of and flips open her suitcase. “The things I do to help you finally get laid.”

Catra ignores her, stripping out of her pants and pulling out a floral dress that hasn’t seen the light of day in months. Thankfully it’s not wrinkled to high heaven.

It’s been nearly two years since Catra’s had to wear one of these on a semi-regular basis and it didnt get less weird in that time. It feels like she’s wearing a bedsheet and not any real clothes at all. Like one good tug is all it would take to make her nude in the streets.

“What, no witty retort?” Lonnie says as she steps into her flats. “No, *‘If your sex life was any good, you wouldn’t be so interested in mine, Lonnie.’”*

Catra clenches her teeth and pulls out her comb. It’s going to take a bit of work to get it into a more feminine style, especially

without a mirror to help. It's been pulled back and up like this so long she isn't even sure if the cowlicks have any fight left in them.

"That is very unlike you, Wildcat." Scorpia adds and Catra glares at her. It's on occasion that the magnifying glass is pointed at her. Every one of them has been under it at some point, but she really wishes Kyle would do something stupid right now to turn the glass on him.

"Huh, Cat usually only clams up like this when it's something personal she doesn't want to share." But no, Kyle pulls out a heater instead and turns this into goddamn firing squad.

"Fucking hell! I spend way too much time with you asshats! We had sex, alright! She blew my damn wig and I'm head over heels. Now can we *please, please* get a cab and not talk about this for at *least* the next 48 hours?"

Rogelio's brow lifts just a hair and he looks at both of his partners. Scorpia starts whistling, answer enough for Catra, though her involvement in this was cursory at best. Kyle and Lonnie look properly wilted by Ro's eyeful of chastisement which helps cool Catra off a tad from being near steaming. Once she's had a moment to breathe, the gentle smile Lonnie gives Catra calms her down even more. It's not even one of apology, it's one that Catra knows says "I'm happy for you." She even smiles back, because yeah, they all like to give each other a hard time, but they also love one another a lot too.

Chapter End Notes

> So I wasn't even sure if they used the term "get laid" back in this era, so I looked it up!
>
> The term "get laid" originates from the early 1900's in Chicago. The Everleigh Club, 1900 -1911, a high class brothel owned by the Everleigh sisters. "Getting Everleigh'd" in the city was just eventually shortened to "laid"

Don’t Mince, Palone-Omi

Chapter Notes

> Ahh yes, would you look at that chapter count. No one saw that coming, especially not me.
>
> I’ve once again, cut this chapter here because it’s so much information to take in all at once, and it felt like a natural ending for a chapter. Idk why that’s important to me, but it is. This is a shorter one, but a lot happens.
>
> I also vow on that all that is queer that more smut, in this *smut fic* will be in the next chapter. I just want to have the room to put in all the fun details I have planned for this.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The cab is a tight fit with all their bags and how huge both Ro and Scorpia are; Catra would much rather sit on Rogelio’s lap than on Kyle’s bony legs, so Lonnie gets to squash the bean pole. Scorpia gets the worst of it though, barely seen under the cargo that they couldn't squeeze into the tiny trunk.

With the sun barely a sliver on the horizon, the city lights up beautifully around them. It's not New York, but the hustle and bustle of the nightlife springing up still has that special charge to it. New York felt like being lost at sea with hundreds of thousands of others swimming in their own current but anywhere you landed felt special. San Francisco, Catra’s favorite, felt like an endless fount of possibilities, complete freedom. It may be surrounded by water but it felt more like an oasis than an island. In her nights here Catra has found that Chicago has an air like its a world all its own, that this city is the only one that exists and be damned if you suggest otherwise. There’s Chicago, and then there’s everywhere else. That’s part of the reason Catra was eager to move on when she woke up this morning. There’s a big world out there and she wants to take as much of it in as she can, but now

here she is looking at the pale brick of a Chi-town laundry service like its the Sistine Chapel for gays.

They can't unload fast enough. If Lonnie tells her to slow her roll one more time… As much as she wants to she just can't stop it, this giddy, nervous, excitement. Catra would rather be the cool and collected version of herself once she sees Adora again. She's hoping that'll come when those long legs are standing in front of her again. When Catra opens the door those nerves get an ice bath and are replaced with a much more twitchy kind.

At the counter are three men, one of which Catra can assume is Micah, based on how Adora described him. He smiles at them warmly as they pile in, taking in the bags they carry with them, but his body is stiff. Catra is unsure of her feet as she moves to the wall. The others prickle up just the same as they walk in and notice the two uniformed officers standing in front of the counter.

"Welcome, you must be the ones who called in for our late night service. Catra right? I'll be with you soon ma'am, once I'm done with these two gentlemen." He nods to them and then addresses the two officers. "I'm happy to see if she free for you, Walter. Both your uniforms should be ready too."

Catra lowers her shoulders and puts on a placid expression as Micah heads through a door. The coppers both turn in their direction and are near identical aside from the expressions on their face. Both are older, salt and pepper hair, gaunt. One's cold, with calculating eyes and the other looks amused. Catra doesn't like either of those looks one bit.

"You know, brother, I heard the funniest phrase the other day?"

"I don't care, Walter."

The policeman whose badge reads W. Hordak turns and leans against the counter, fully facing them now. Scorpia tenses and Catra sees Rogelio fist his hand around the knife in his pocket.

"I overheard this moll in lock up say, *'I'm no lilly naff, so don't mince palone-omi.' "*
(I'm no awful, hetero cop, so don't run, lesbian.)

Catra could collapse on the spot with how quickly the tension leaves her body. It's been a while since she's heard that kind of talk, not since New York. The language is used quite a bit on the east coast, which makes sense because that's where it migrated to first from the English sailors, but maybe it's widespread here too. She hasn't really gotten into situations to use it recently. Which, objectively, is a good thing.

The rest settle too at the nonsense to unknowing ears, no longer ready to sprint to the door. W. Hordak—Walter—winks at her and leans toward his twin. "What do you think it means Harry?"

"It's just made up Italian nonsense. The fuck should I- Oh, Entrapta! Forgive my language."

Catra hadn't noticed the arrival of the short, pigtailed woman either. She just kind of… appeared.

"Here's your uniform Harold. Wally, yours is still hanging. I'd like to stay a while, I'm so so close to getting Emily working!"

"Of course sweetheart." Walter says and then pouts. "Wait, who's Emily?"

"Electric, machined, in home, laundry unit." Entrapta says proudly and hugs Walter. She stays under his arm as he looks down in confusion.

"Well, I'm glad you found a name for it, dear. But why the 'Y'?"

"Emilu sounds too much like emu."

Harold is standing awkwardly, his hands behind his back, clenching as he takes his twin and the small woman in. Now that Catra knows she's not in immediate danger, she could really go for some popcorn with this show. "You're so wonderfully smart,

Entrapta. A mind like yours could do so much. I'm positive I still could get our father to let you work at the station. If you ever change your mind. We could visit it again after Emily is completed? Over dinner?" Oh, his tone is almost flirtatious. Catra can taste the salted butter on her tongue.

"Nah, I'd much rather better people's lives than ruin them." Entrapta says nonchalantly and Walter starts laughing nervously. Kyle's peepers are wide as dinner plates he looks like he's about to pass out. Lonnie puts her hand over his and squeezes, looking just as amused as Catra does.

"Isn't *my* wife just the *funniest,* Harry? You go on ahead, brother. Looks like I'm going to be giving Mrs. Hordak a hand for a while. I'll see you at the station Monday."

Once his figure disappears into one of the parked cars out front, Walter takes off his cap and let's out an exasperated sigh. "When will he quit with that, Trap? That's half the reason we married, and still."

"I think Harold thinks he can out macho you or something, Wally." Entrapta shakes her head. "All my research and still can't figure out how to get him to let it go. If it comes down to it, I'll fight him for both of us. You know your boyfriend will too. He's waiting for you downstairs, by the way."

"Thank you, Trap. I'd do my best too, but we both know I'm a lover and not a fighter. Do you want me to help you? I can before I go see Cobalt? Coby would lend a hand too."

"Ah, that's not necessary, Wally." Entrapta says as she unwraps herself. "I will be down later however. Adora says she's-" Catra must lean forward at the mention of that name because pigtails glances at her and stops short of her next word. "I think this might be one of those times when I *shouldn't* repeat the thing everyone knows, when it involves someone who doesn't."

“No, please, go on.” Lonnie says excitedly, rapidly shifting her gaze from Entrapta to Catra. Catra *wants* to glare at her, but she also really wants to know.

Entrapta shrugs and looks back up at Walter. “She’s in love. Said it was at first sight. Fascinating! I must collect data about this phenomenon.”

Scorpia is positively beaming at Catra, who feels like she’s possibly just died.

Walter’s mouth hangs open a few times. “Well, that’s just neat! You were also correct about not repeating it. We’ll keep working on it. No worry though, no marriage proposal has been foiled this time.”

There goes all hope Catra has at being cool as a cucumber when she sees her. The logical part of her mind is telling her that she should be perturbed by this. The entire rest of her body just feels warm, like her soul is burning so hot it’s trying to escape. A small part is still reserved for debating whether to punch, or kiss Lonnie.

“Well, young’n’s.” Walter turns to them with a clap of his hands. “You’re here for the moonlight services I presume?”

“Uhh…” Kyle shuffles closer to Catra and nudges her back to the present. “What’s the password again?” He mumbles.

Catra shakes her head. This is fine. “Asking for the moonlight services is the password, dolt.” She did realize, down in that fake mine, that she is in love too, as ridiculous as that is.

“Fantastic! You’s all can follow me-“

She just didn’t think it would be possible that Adora could feel the same way. It doesn’t change much, but it also changes *everything.*

“Hold on” Catra stops walking towards the door W. Hordak is holding. “But you’re a cop!? Why do you know about this place? How can we trust you? Just because you're fluent, doesn’t mean we’re not walking into trouble. You still have a badge.”

Walter starts unbuttoning his over shirt and with a jut of his hip, smiles at her. “What, never seen a sheep in wolf's clothing before?” When Catra doesn’t budge he sighs. “Look, I told you I’m no lilly naff. My pa is the chief of police, a prime source of information to keep all you’s baby gays safe. I didn’t have much of a choice at the time, but now all the places for we *fancy* folk are mysteriously empty when us pigs arrive. I understand though. I can get Micah if you want. He just really hates my brother. I can barely tolerate him and we shared a womb.”

Catra nods, at what part exactly she isn’t sure. These past five minutes have been a wild ride of different emotions and she’s still gathering her wits. “Ooor.” Walter whisps as she walks by him, his foot propping the door open for them. “I can get that fiery blonde for you.”

Walter leads them to the far end of the room that’s stacked high with clothes. He plucks a few off the rack and tells them to wait. There’s the roar of air as they stand in front of tall cabinet dryers, waiting for him to return.

“So uh, love huh?” Scorpia says to the air, pointedly not looking at Catra. “That’s powerful stuff.”

“Sure is.” Catra also doesn’t look at her. Her mouth feels incredibly dry. She cannot wait to get a drink, or three.

“You know, Catra, none of us will hold it against you if we just scram. I’d get it. That’s uh, kind of loony. I know you’ve cut n’ run for less.” Lonnie also says to the air in front of them, rocking on her heels.

Catra is grateful that they aren’t looking at her, she’s not sure she could say it otherwise. “Yeah, well, it’s not like she said it to *me*

directly.” Catra finds a very interesting frayed end to pluck at on the strap of her dress. “And maybe I’m uh, feelin’ a bit *loony* myself.”

The polite look away has ended and they are all staring at her with raised brows. Rogelio’s is the worst, that man says more with his face than a politician on the pulpit who's about to lose his seat.

“Shut the hell up, Ro. Not a word from any of y’all either.”

They don’t even get a chance to say anything because Walter returns in cheery plain clothes. “You’s can change down there. They may all know me, but it’s best if I don’t show up looking like the brass. Now-“ He reaches toward the cabinet dryer’s and pulls two open. The door looks like two and on the inside they are divided like two also. Walter pushes the false divider to the side and waves them in. “There’s a latch on the side of the back. Just give her a push and I’ll close it back up behind us.”

It’s a tight fit, especially with their belongings but Catra gets the door open easily enough. As she starts down the steps music hits her ears, no longer drowned out by the furnace’s hot air. They’ve been to a number of speakeasies before, some ritzy, others obviously thrown together basement bars, but at a glance this one feels homey. Like a place you’d entertain company for a night of catching up and card games. The lights are soft and warm and the furniture she spots from the stairwell is nice but not ornate. Definitely homey.

“Hawk, you promise me, swear right now that this bottle is gin and not our cleaning product.”

Catra stops on the last step hidden by the half wall and bites her lip as it curls into a smile.

“I swear on my sweet Mermista-“

“Oh no, you keep me out of this sailor boy.”

“I’m a man of my word, Adora. This is the gin that I just finished infusing.”

“Take a drink then, Hawk. Because I don’t smell any juniper in this. I’m not getting sick again and smelling like a distillery because I’m sweating out our dry cleaning product all night.”

There are, unfortunately, people behind her so she can’t stand here forever, listening and unsure how to approach this impossible woman again after everything. It was so easy at the time, but when they parted ways it almost felt like all that had been a dream. ‘Yes, hello again. I’m head over heels for you even though I don’t know your last name and after you brought me over the edge the only concrete thought I had was ‘I want to be in these arms forever.’ Do you serve whiskey?’ This is the first time she’s faced this problem. Of all the consequences of all her actions, this is one she is willing to accept.

Catra finishes her way down the stairs and drops her things to the floor without ceremony. All eyes immediately turn to the newcomers, except for one burly man who watches Walter pass right by them, planting a kiss on his cheek when he arrives.

Adora looks… amazing. Catra can feel her cheeks change color as Adora finds her. Those suspenders don’t let her t-shirt hide anything, from breasts to bulging biceps as she holds a jug of what Catra guesses to be the mystery liquid that was up for debate.

Adora shoves the jug into mustache man’s arms and hops over the bar, even though it’s open ended. If Catra weren’t so gobsmacked, she’d laugh.

“Hi.” Adora says, standing a good three feet away. Her hands are stuffed into her pockets and this immediate shyness has transformed Catra’s heart into a hummingbird.

“Hi.” Catra, breathlessly, says right back.

“You made it. Find it okay?”

“Yup.”

Everyone is still staring as they awkwardly stand there, the pause between them growing ever longer. But all Catra seems to care about is how Adora keeps looking at the floor, her cheeks as pink as peach blossoms and worrying her full, soft lips. All that worry Catra held before slips down to her socks. What boils up to take its place is just a feeling of unbridled joy at the sight of that face.

“I’m going to kiss you now, if that’s okay?” Catra asks curtly, fighting the urge to clear her throat.

“Good. Yup! Excellent.” Adora nods, and they both chuckle nervously.

Catra steps forward, grabs Adora by the collar and gently pulls her down and in. And there it is, that wonderfully unique way that Adora kisses. Catra has kissed people in the rain, on the docks, in the train. Most of those kisses were quite good but no one has ever kissed Catra, to kiss *her* . It’s an action that feels good, your lips searching for just the right places to draw the most reward. Even in the pinch of teeth to make moans, it’s been for the other person’s pleasure. It isn’t inherently bad, she’s always done the same. But to be kissed like *this* , with a searing intensity that’s all for her. It makes her knees shake, and Catra moves her lips to return just the same.

Soft hair is brushing up against Catra’s cheek, the prettiest privacy curtain for their little moment as they draw back. Their noses are pressed together so she can only see a bit of her but Catra can see the smile around her eyes just as well. “I’m gonna test what you said today. About me kissin’ you.”

“I’m looking forward to it.” Adora whispers back and Catra gives her one last little peck before letting the collar of her shirt go.

Chapter End Notes

The language W. Hordak used is Polari! Give a look up to the history of lavender language. Fascinating stuff! And if it

wasn’t clear, Entrapta and Hordak are in a beard marriage.

Speak Easy

Chapter Notes

> Still on Catra's pov but I wanted to assure you that we'll get Adora's again. I'm waiting for a specific moment.
>
> Pre read Polari lesson. Tipping the velvet is oral sex.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra has always leaned toward girls. Her first crush at age six with Julie Hoper down the street. The girl who gladly would play house with all the neighbor kids as long as she was the mommy, and scrawny little Catra was the daddy. There were many secret crushes as she got older, and some not so secret like her love for the gorgeous, famous, singing wonder, Josephine Baker.

Catra's come to learn many things about her love for women. She likes em pretty, she likes em masculine, curvy, buff, she just plane ole adores them in all shapes and sizes. Of all these likes, loves and wants, Adora is burning so brightly. As far as Catra's concerned, Adora is the most perfect thing she's ever seen.

Yet, after introductions, getting changed into a set of much more comfortable clothes, and a few stiff drinks, Catra's biggest temptation appears. There's honky tonk piano playing from the record player, specifically the 12th Street Rag, one her father used to love to play, and a pretty thing in a flapper dress.

So that's how, in Catra's life long history of loving to love women her first dance of the night is not with Adora who she can barely tear her eyes off of, but with Kyle who looks *stunning* in that dress and is having a blast being led around the dance floor in turn by Lonnie, Catra and Adora. Kyle, much to his credit, is having no problem keeping up with his dance partners.

Bow is in the corner, tapping his toes to the beat and starts the chorus of whistles as Catra whirls Kyle around, dives him between

her legs only to be caught by Adora and flipped into an excited lindy hop that Catra cannot wait to be on the receiving end of. She catches her breath, thankful she forwent the button up as sweat starts to form. The furnace provides cover for the music and chatter, but also makes the Brightmoon Ballroom more than cozy. Just as Catra is about to get back in on the action, a drink is in her hand and Lonnie is looking at her with fire in her eyes.

"Whas' this?" She sniffs the glass. It doesn't look like any of the Brightmoon brews Adora explained to her. It must be a mix from the few labeled bottles on the shelf. There's a sweet smell to it, like blackberry and citrus. It seems familiar.

"We had this in New York. This is a celebration of you getting *frisky.* "

Catra narrows her eyes but when Lonnie moves to take the drink back she downs it. It is sweet, a hint of blackberry, with a smooth burn and a curious viscosity. She's definitely had this before. "Yeah, I recall this. What's in'it? It's really good."

"Well, hopefully you get more tonight. It's called, *tipping the velvet.* " Lonnie winks at her and Catra feels that she must be redder than the flushed and winded Kyle being hopped around. "Now, I'm taking my man back. He's just so pretty right now. Go dance with Adora that you're so in *loony* with."

As Lonnie steals Kyle away the music fades and the dapper dressed Netossa practically flings herself to the record shelf. "I know what will get everrrry one moving'."

Adora walks back towards Catra, one hand raised conspiratorially as she leans into Catra's ear. "Someone has had a bit more giggle juice than usual." Adora says with a snicker, then notices Catra's glass and spins back around to the bar. "Oh, shoot!"

Catra laughs and wraps an arm around her waist. "Dollll, Perfuma took over a while ago. Poured our drinks even." Adora even said

thank you to the other long legged blonde as she was leaning over the bar, chatting away with Catra.

“Don’t worry about it, Dor. You’re still getting your money. Have some fun tonight, dear.” Adora starts to protest until she sees Perfuma lean in awful close to Scorpia over the counter.

“I still feel bad.” Adora says, pouting, and if she ain’t living up to her name.

“How’r’ya so stink’n cute?”

As the words come out of Catra’s mouth, she thinks that maybe she too has hit the hooch a bit too hard given how little she’s eaten today.

Adora looks down at her, grinning from ear to ear. “So, three drinks is all it takes, huh?”

Catra pouts at her out of principal, even if that smile is one she’d love to see again and again. “Three fer what?”

“For that watered down Georgia peach to come back full bloom.”

“Oh like you don’t talk funny all the time. All’y’all do.” Catra says, waving her empty glass around at the room. As long as she stays aware she’s doing it, she could go back to the inflections more suited to northern tastes, but she has a point to make. What point exactly, she’s not sure, but the alcohol in her veins is set on it.

“All’y’us huh?” Adora teases, and Catra sticks her tongue out at her.

“Yes. Say it with me Adora. Bo-tt-le. It’s bottle.” Catra straightens herself, puffing up and putting on her best Chicagoian imitation. “Not, ‘boddle’. Where’da T’s go, anyhow?”

They are momentarily distracted by music coming to life, and then Netossa’s groaning. “Wrong one!” she proclaims, and throws the

record toward the wall. Glimmer practically teleports from her seat and barely manages to catch it.

"You're cut off, Net." Glimmer tells her in a huff, setting the record back down safely on a nearby surface.

"The hell I'm letting a five year old tell me I can't drink anymore." Netossa crosses her arms… and blows a raspberry at her. Glimmer takes the bait in the form of blocking Netossa from the rest of the records and Catra is glad for it. For some damn reason, this sparkling short stack has been giving her the stink eye since Glimmer got down here. Both Bow and Spinnerella sigh as they walk past Catra. At least now Adora's sister-esc family member has something else to occupy her.

"As I was'a say'n," Catra whips back around and has to take a sudden step back, she was so close that if Adora had been looking down at all it would've been a kiss.

"I think you were complaining about my T's, Catra. Well I think you like the way I *tease* , just fine." Adora reaches out, running her fingers down the seam on the arm of Catra's tank top. Adora pinches her fingers together, pressing into the ribbed fabric, just barely grazing Catra's skin with her knuckles. It's definitely affecting, especially when Adora traces the swell of her breast on her way down.

There's a cacophony of sounds coming from over by the record player and excited conversation, but it's all white noise with the way a set of two piercing blue eyes are looking at her. Adora is looking at her like she had in the picture palace, with a focused, all consuming intensity that pins Catra's feet to the floor. She sets her empty glass down on one the nearby tables that surround the small dance floor and curls her fingers around Adora's waist instead.

"Hush, you." It doesn't sound commanding at all. "You think you're so cute."

“You did just say I was.” Adora says with a stupid, sexy, smug smile. “So stink’n cute, I think.”

“Well, you do know how to fluster a girl. So do I, darlin.” Catra brings her other hand up to Adora’s hip and pulls her in close.

Adora’s lips brush against Catra’s temple as she speaks, and Catra would very much like to feel them in other places. “Hmm. I don’t think it’ll work on me, Catra.”

“You see, I hide my accent for a couple of reasons, angel.” Catra slides her hands to the small of Adora’s back, and arches so they are joined at the hip. Adora grips Catra just the same. “You city people would take me for stupid, but there’s also because—” Catra pauses her softly spoken words and kisses the corner of Adora’s mouth that’s upturned in a coy smile. “I don’t think there’s been a northern lady with our predilections, who can resist me sayin’ in this voice that your lips look sweet as clementines, that your eyes remind me of warm spring skies, and your smile fills me up like fresh baked apple pie, and I’d like you to prove me wrong, *sugar* .”

Adora either can’t or won’t prove her wrong, and Catra is fine with either reason. It might be a bit of a problem that Catra forgets other people exist when Adora is so close, kissing her like it’s the only thing she ever wants to be doing, because Catra lets a moan escape that has Walter give them a return to earth cough. They are both grinning like goons, content to keep making and breaking eye contact when it gets whelming as they remain slotted against each other.

The ruckus near the record player has calmed down with a brokered peace agreement. Netossa will switch to water if they can find her damn song. To which Adora asks what record she’s looking for. Netossa answers by humming it, the name escaping her now that she’s put on the spot.

“Third shelf up, seventh over.” Adora says and only moves to cup Catra’s face and run her fingers through Catra’s hair. It feels so

normal to lean into the touch, as if this is a position they've been in a thousand and one times now.

"This is nice." Catra mumbles, lost on the tingles down her spine as Adora's nails graze her scalp.

"It is…" Catra opens her eyes back up at the curious way Adora sounded, almost hesitant. She definitely looks a little anxious. "You know, I know we don't really know each other but… this um… feels…" It feels special. Catra finishes for her in her thoughts. It feels like a once in a lifetime thing, if you're ever lucky enough to have that "once" happen at all. It feels like decisions Catra's not ready to think about yet and acknowledging it out loud might lead to conversations about what's next.

Familiar piano keys ring through the air, and it seems Netossa was right. Nearly everyone pulls their attention to the receiver. Spinnerella pulls her drunken partner out to the dance floor first. The playful trumpet not even a crotchety old man could resist moving too, calls Catra's name just in the nick of time.

"Let's see if those long arms n' legs can keep up with me." Catra steps back and pulls Adora's hands into her own. Adora smiles but to Catra it's plainly attempting to hide the disappointment that started to flash across her face. It shouldn't hurt as much as it does. "Unless you'd rather toss Kyle around again. Wouldn't hold it against you, that dress is…" Catra kisses her teeth and Adora laughs with a shake of her head.

"You're going to be the one trying to keep up."

Adora wasn't wrong. Catra's never had a competition *with* her dance partner before, but Adora keeps surprising her by changing their step mid step. She already saw her Lindy, but then Adora moves them to a rock step, west coast style. Out of the Charleston she moves to triplestep and it's obvious that Adora's just showing off. Maybe it's time to start making good on her threat.

Just as Adora starts to lift her for a spin, Catra plants her feet and falls back into her chest. “Kiss?” Catra asks, looking up at Adora mischievously. “You said the answer’s never no, and keep us in rhythm, doll.”

Adora barks out a laugh so hard she snorts, and that shouldn’t be charming but it is. Adora steps back and Catra starts to fall. With one low rock step back Adora catches her by the shoulder, plants one on her, and springs Catra back up.

They aren’t the only ones making a game of it. As Catra keeps hiking up the stakes at choosing increasingly inopportune times to demand a smooch, the others seem to be in a dance off of sorts on their own. Each take turns as the songs play on, galavanting down the middle of an impromptu runway. Catra nearly trips when she sees Rogelio shuffle down the center, Lonnie and Kyle both following his quick steps.

They aren’t left to do their own thing for long. Mermista slides up unexpectedly and hip checks Catra almost completely out of Adora’s arms.

“Sorry to break up this disgustingly lovey thing you got going on here. Seriously, can you go two minutes without kissing each other? Anyway, I want to win this thing and my husband is a dead hoofer.” Both Catra and Adora turn to where Mermista is thumbing them to. Seahawk has a beer lifted to the sky, arm and arm with Bow, as he spins Bow around, stomping to a beat of his own. “So I need one of ya to let me strut my stuff.”

Catra is fucking parched, and Adora doesn’t look any better. The heat plus the footwork has made each kiss progressively saltier. “I’ll get us some city juice. Adora if you wanna take the first go, and I’ll out do you on the second?”

Adora laughs and pinches Catra on the cheek. “You are so full of yourself.”

“Ha! I’m full of myself?! Okay, Miss, let's do every swing step known to man for no good reason.”

The glint in Adora’s eye should’ve been adequate warning that Catra was about to lose the use of her tongue. “Hey, I’m not complaining. Matter of fact, I wouldn’t mind being full of you myself, kitten.” Adora says oh so casually as she squeezes Catra’s fingers that were yet lingering in her hand.

Memories from just a few hours ago come flooding back, and visions of a possible very near future. It was hard enough to tamper down the ache of Adora’s quickened breath in her ear brought on without the blatant statement of the fact that Adora wants Catra that way. Catra’s body is a turpentine derived of gooey affection, awe and level of lust that was all new to her. How did people function like this? Catra’s mouth hangs open as Mermista laughs and suddenly Adora is looking embarrassed too, like she forgot her new dance partner was standing right next to her.

“That water. I’m gonna. Uh. Go get it.” Catra might even go dunk her head in the sink and see if steam rises. She downs one glass and pours two more herself, the bar abandoned in the wake of the flirtatious air around Scorpia and Perfuma. Thoughts of fingers and the spots on Adora’s body she’s nervous and aching to touch are pushed aside by the scene before her. This thing she’s feeling for this wonder who came out of nowhere isn’t the only special thing Catra’s experiencing tonight.

It’s a bar, sure, but it feels more like a big family gathering instead that she and the crew were sucked into. Adora told her the only reason they charge for drinks at all is so this little space can pay for itself, the rest going to whomever’s slinging the swigs. Everyone is cozy with each other, giving playful jeers, cheers and hanging off one another, and not a single one of them is related. It’s a lot like Catra’s little family she’s built except these people have one place that they can all be. She wouldn’t want to leave this all behind, if it’s what her family had. Catra doesn’t want to leave what her family has now, each other, and the possibility of

going absolutely anywhere. Both were good. Catra couldn't ask anyone to trade one for the other.

Rash decisions are kind of Catra's thing. Usually they're ones that lead to the least emotional devastation. Leaving home. Giving in out of loneliness to Scorpia's offer to join them in the boxcar when Catra was trying to find one of her own inspite of how dangerous it could've been. Disappearing when a gal's smile started to mean more than a beautiful face. Disappearing whenever a gal asked her where home was. Telling Adora the truth of that home for no other reason than to try to quiet the envy and *want* in those eyes at the way she was dressed. Those eyes got Catra in this mess she finds herself in. There's no decision to be had on what she wants with Adora, her heart has already made that lighting choice against her will. As Catra watches Mermista and Adora make the music jealous of their rhythm, both of their families caught in a picturesque joy, she wishes there was an easy choice to make.

Catra never gets her chance to partner up with Mermista. The arrival of food is signaled by Hawk loudly yelling "Your Majesty!" toward the stairwell. In the stairwell stands, both quite surprised, Micha and Angella carrying a pot, bowls, and the unmistakable smell of a sweet potato pie.

"New faces always get pie." Adora explains.

Angella keeps glancing at Catra, Ro, Kyle, Lonnie and Scorp as they eat. It's obvious both her and Micha want to talk to them but they have their hands full trying to make sleeping arrangements for a far to drunk Net *and* Spinny. Catra's more than fine with that because she'd much rather soak up the rest of this dwindling evening with Adora.

It appears that the only people leaving tonight are Walt, Colby and Entrapta who emerged from *somewhere* at the sight of a personal sized pie. Catra's barely finished with a mouth watering stew when Adora gets her attention with a light touch on her arm.

“So um, it looks like things are probably winding down here, and I heard mention of the Cubs and Sox game tomorrow from Hawk, and that can get pretty out of hand in this house. We’re actually not allowed to all listen to the same radio when they play. Anyways, I was wondering if you’d like to… go somewhere else? I, my, uh, bed is small but, uh—” Adora is looking up like the words she’s trying to say are stuck to the ceiling. Catra feels like she could probably jump to the ceiling with how hard her heart has suddenly started working. “Also, even though they put a shower in the downstairs for me, the hot water goes quick. So if you want to take one before bed…”

“Yeah, Adora.” Catra manages to say by throwing a blanket over the other implications there in her mind. She pulls Adora’s hand into hers and slides off of her seat. Catra is, can be, smooth as silk. Known for it even, except when it comes to Adora apparently. She goes to say, “Let’s go to bed,” but is also thinking about that shower, about Adora in the shower, and says, “Let’s go get wet,” instead.

Lonnie, the damn eavesdropper, slaps her hand over mouth to keep the food in as she laughs. Even though Catra’s cheeks are blazing and a heap of embarrassment just fell out of her, that special spot reserved just for Lonnie is hoping that she chokes. “Cuz uh, the shower.” Catra amends.

Hand in hand and with a few calls of good night, Catra is led to the short staircase she spotted earlier on the other side of the room. She ignores the snickers from Lonnie, drilling her eyes into Adora’s broad shoulders as she opens the door and pushes aside… clothes?

“I’ve been to quite a few speakeasies, but I’ve never come out of the closet before. You get your own secret entrance?”

“Sort of, yeah. When they turned this into a bedroom for me I still wanted there to be an emergency exit, so we built a closet around the door just in case the coppers ever come sniffing around. It’s nice though not having to go outside all the time to get to my

room, especially in the winter." Once they get past the doors it takes a bit of awkward shuffling for Adora to be able to close them again. She wasn't exaggerating when she said it was a tight space, but it doesn't feel cramped either with the little pieces of Adora dispersed throughout.

Adora has to scoot the bed away from the door to get the bathroom door open all the way. They are both obviously awkward about it as Adora finds pajamas for them both to change into. Catra left all her things by the end of the bar, and like hell is she going to walk back down there again while Lonnie is still conscious and capable of speech.

Catra takes probably the most thorough shower of her life while also trying to stop the ferris wheel in her stomach from spinning out of control. She's had sex now, it's fine. There's no actual indication that *that's* going to happen tonight but she can't stop thinking about it, how nice it would feel to run her hands all over Adora's skin, what her biceps might feel like between her teeth, how intoxicating the sound of Adora gasping for breath as Catra breaks her over the edge must be.

The pj's are far too big for her, the neckline of the navy button up hanging low. She was worried at first about just looking like a frump in them but the way it accentuates her cleavage, Catra might dare to say she looks sexy, and a bit dashing in this.

Catra resists letting her smile get too broad at Adora's reaction to her. Adora eyes flicker down more than once and she fumbles over her words to excuse herself as she goes to wash up.

Catra seats herself on the bed, running her hand over the colorful and carefully stitched quilt. There's not much to the room, but what is here is carefully curated. On the nightstand is a small framed photograph of whom Catra guesses to be Adora, no older than ten with her mother and probably her grandmother. She looks so cute in the sundress, holding a wicker basket and beaming at the camera. On the wall hangs a folded and framed

American flag just above a cork board that's littered with newspaper clippings.

There's a few local events on there, results for a baseball game or two along with some pictures of various White Sox players. Most of the clippings though are photographs of various places throughout the U.S. Catra recognizes one photo immediately as the Grand Canyon, one of the most beautiful places she's ever been.

She wants to investigate further but there's no time for that when Adora emerges from the bathroom looking like any gay woman's domestic bliss. Catra might be swimming in these pajamas but they fit Adora's frame perfectly, her strong shoulders filling the men's top like it was made for her. Not to mention how sexy her hair looks.

The bed dips as Adora sits next to her, still making an effort to towel dry her hair. They are close together but that small gap between them might as well be a grand canyon of its own for how hard Catra's mind is working for how to reach over and touch her.

"Thank you for coming here tonight. Also for today. I don't remember the last time I've had such an exciting day."

"Yeah," Catra replies as she worries her lips. "It was a pretty fantastic day."

"Um, before we lay down there's something I wanted to tell you." Adora takes a deep breath and sets her towel aside. Adora crosses the canyon for Catra, placing her hand atop Catra's knee. "It's okay if you, I don't know. I know you probably meet a lot of people, a lot of women, but I feel really lucky to have met you, even if this only for a day."

Catra wants to say something, but the clockwork inside is stuck on trying to find the perfect reply. An impossible task.

At Catra's silence, Adora continues with an apparent forced casualness. "This, between us feels like something special. Again,

it’s okay if you don’t feel the same, Catra. I don’t often *meet* people but even if I did… I think I’d still feel the same. I just… wanted you to know this.”

Catra’s heart is thumping loud as a rabbit's foot in her ears as she takes in Adora’s nervousness. The hard swallow, the glancing away to stare at her own finger nails. She knows, thanks to Entrapta, what Adora isn’t saying. It’s those three little words that feel impossible to feel in less than a day.

“I know it’s silly.” Adora adds, shifting uncomfortably and finally the gears start to mesh together and move Catra into action if only to keep that face from becoming more crestfallen.

“It’s not silly, Adora.” Catra says dryly, taking Adora’s hand into hers. “This is special. I feel it too. And um, I may be a terrible flirt, but I’ve never really felt anything strong or um...” Catra turns away from her, squeezing Adora’s hand for the new security found there. “You see, I… at the picture palace. I’ve never gotten to, or really wanted to do that with someone before. So yeah, I think this is something unique between us.”

Catra is barely breathing as she waits for Adora’s response. It doesn’t come and Catra fights through her embarrassment to turn back toward her. She finds Adora’s brows pinched and confused.

“Wait, when you said you’d never… Oh God! I had no idea, that’s why you were nervous—”

“It’s really not a big deal—”

“And it was in public! I’m so—”

“Adora, really. Please—”

“sorry, Catra! If I had actually—”

Adora finally shuts up when Catra buries her burning face into the mattress. This talking about shit sucks, feelings included. She feels so exposed and embarrassed. No wonder she's never done it before. The only reason her friends knew is because Catra met up with them extra late one night, Lonnie made a snide comment about Catra being a serial heart grifter just to get into skirts and Catra had just literally fled from a heavy petting session with a beautiful woman. She was raw, angry with herself and a little drunk. To Lonnie's credit she was actually really sweet about it at the time, but they wouldn't be them if it didn't turn into the occasional ribbing.

"You don't have to apologize. It was… great okay?" Catra moves just enough to keep her words from being muffled but she's not sure when her face is going to be making an appearance any time soon.

"Okay but…" Adora sighs and Catra relaxes a little from the soothing touch now moving across her back. "I can't imagine that's how you thought it would happen. At least somewhere more private." There's a stronger dip in the bed next to her and when the hand on her back moves through Catra's hair she turns a little bit more to see Adora with those perfect blue eyes and soft lips just inches away. "You deserve more than that." Adora finishes softly.

Catra lets the surprisingly easy silence in the air stay afloat for a moment. She just looks at her and feels most of the awkwardness drain from her through the strokes in her hair. It's going to be impossible to leave this. "Well, no, it's not how I imagined but I'm basically homeless. It's not like I have a cozy room like this to bring someone back to."

"I don't know…" Adora trails off wistfully and then gets a mischievous look in her eyes. "I'd let you rock my *box—car.*"

Catra rolls her eyes so hard it hurts before the laughter inevitably spills out. Adora's smile only gets prouder when Catra playfully

smacks her on the shoulder. “That was so off the cob. I can’t believe I like you.”

“Me either.” Adora eventually says and scoots closer. She wraps an arm around Catra’s shoulders, prompting her to scooch in herself. They are nose to nose and Catra feels so warm, so damn happy and comfortable it feels surreal. This can’t be what love is like, but when Adora presses a kiss to her cheek and nuzzles in, Catra can’t imagine there could be anything better.

“You know,” Adora says in a whisper. “we are in a cozy room now. If you want, you can show me what you imagined? Or we can just cuddle like this all night. I’m just happy you’re —” Catra interrupts her with a press of her lips, pleased to drink in the content sigh that Adora releases.

“We can cuddle all night, after?” Catra asks even though she knows the answer. A nervous bubble forms in her chest as Adora nods and pulls her into another kiss. Unlike the other times she’s been propositioned, the nervousness is an excited one, just like it had been at the theater. Her body doesn’t want to run, it wants to cling instead. This time they don’t need to rush either. She can, and will take her time.

Chapter End Notes

> Look, I know I lied again. I don’t want to rush it! So much happened here and I want to let Catra’s eyes linger for as long as they want. The smut will 💯 be in the next chapter because it’s the start of the chapter. (also if you see that 6 turn into an 7, no you didn’t. It depends on how the next chapter pans out)

Aces

Chapter Summary

It's basically near 4k words of soft smut, enjoy.

Chapter Notes

Sorry about the delay. I got a period from hell and now I have a, something, going on.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

If the hitching of Adora's breath were a siren song, Catra would have drowned to keep hearing it. Once she finally frees herself from Adora's lips, Catra moves onto her neck, kissing, marking, nipping, searching for the spots that are making Adora's legs a vice on her knee out of desperation for friction.

Catra slows her movements, rucking up the hem of Adora's shirt to trace her hand along the soft, warm skin underneath. She lets Adora settle, going back to kissing her long and slow with just the hint of tongue on her lips. Just when the grip on Catra's ass lax she turns it up a notch again, taking Adora's lower lip between her teeth and squeezing Adora's hip possessively, pushing her down into the mattress as her hips try to close the distance to Catra's knee once again.

"You doing alright?" Catra says with a devious smile as she pulls away. Honestly, she's not faring much better. The hope was that she'd overcome the nerves by sheer hornyness, and she has. However , seeing Adora so eager for her that she's straining is *doing things* to Catra.

"Mmhmm." Adora hums through tight lips and an enthusiastic nod. "Peachy keen here. Take as long as you need."

Catra suppresses a laugh and lets out an exaggerated sigh instead. "Another 30 or so of this and then…" She turns away,

feigning thoughtfulness but keeps Adora in her periphery. It must have been forty minutes of this kissing and teasing already, any longer and Catra would combust. Adora's eyes go wide for a moment and she swallows hard. That cracked her. Catra laughs. "Im kidding. I think that would kill you."

"I'd die happy. Seriously, whatever you need. I want you to be comfortable, Catra."

Catra smiled so much today that her cheeks hurt but she can't seem to stop doing it. She sits up and eyes Adora, chewing her lip. "I'm ready, doll. Can I, um," Catra toys with the hem of Adora's shirt between her fingers. "take this off?"

"Yeah." Adora replies quickly. "Would it be okay if you took yours off too? No pressure if you don't want—" Adora clams back up and watches intently as Catra makes slow work of her own buttons. As eager as Catra is to get Adora's shirt off too, toying with her is so much fun.

She makes a show of it, slipping off the top slowly, the focused attention of Adora's gaze bolstering her confidence. Catra tosses the garment to the side casually and Adora has lost the ability to maintain eye contact all together. Adora props herself on her elbows to get a better look, eventually letting out a long exhale. "You are so beautiful."

It's strange to be bashful after the fact, but Catra blushes and tucks her chin in. She finds ample distraction by running her hands over Adora's stomach before landing on the first button. Catra's not taking this one slow, in fact she has to pace herself to keep from seeming *too* eager. Every inch of warm skin revealed is a gift that Catra grants appreciation for, but once all the buttons are undone, the parted fabric flung to the side, Catra just sits there, and stares. She already knew that Adora's nipples were hard while she was working her up but it takes everything to not just lean down and take one in her mouth. Adora's tits are just so perfect, so gorgeous. They're just… "Aces."

Adora throws her head back in a fit of giggling. Catra only stops looking at her bouncing tits when she realizes *why* Adora is giggling. Catra buries her face into her hands instead of those perfect tits like she intended. The laughter finally starts to calm down and Catra is pulled out of her shame by a gentle grip on her wrist after she feels Adora sit up.

"Aces, huh?" Adora says with her a lingering chuckle and Catra groans. "Hey, I'm not laughing *at* you, okay?" She says gently and presses a kiss to Catra's cheek. "It was just really cute, is all."

"Whatever." Catra huffs and attempts a glower in spite of the smile she has to mirror Adora's. "I'm not cute though." Catra juts her chin up, rolling her shoulders back as Adora's touch is tracing her arm. "I think I'm rather rugged, actually."

There's a low throaty growl of approval from Adora as she explores the dips and pools over the lean muscle of Catra's arms. "You're that, *and* cute." Adora says quietly, as if she's talking to herself. That prompts Catra to look back down at her, just in time to see Adora pressing a kiss to her collar bone, and then another. Adora's curious hands move from her arm over to Catra's ribs, touching so lightly it nearly tickles. "I think yours are *aces* , too."

Catra is about to make fun of Adora's hyper focus on her breasts but then she dips down lower. What comes out instead is a pathetic whimper when Adora's hot tongue brushes over her painfully hard nipple. She does it again before capturing completely and sucking. "Not fair." Catra strains out with a gasp, her hips moving on their own accord. As if Adora's mouth wasn't bad enough, those wandering hands of hers are squeezing the insides of her thighs, and the cherry on top of this all the way, horny sundae is the throaty moan Adora releases at Catra's searching hips.

The heat between her legs and well placed thumb has Catra almost forgetting all the things that *she* wants to do to Adora. Catra pushes Adora back by the shoulders, her mouth leaving her nipple with a wet pop. Catra half regrets her decision until she

sees the hazy look in Adora’s eyes. She pushes her again, and Adora follows the silent order to lay back down.

She was close to the edge as it was, but now Catra is feeling positively feral. “Nuh uh, doll.” Catra says as she crawls up to loom over her. Catra pushes her knee to Adora’s center, stopping that smug expression in its tracks. Catra moves her leg a little until a moan hits her ears, cueing Catra’s body into action. She starts with what she already knows she’s excellent at, a searing kiss that ends with Adora’s lip between her teeth before moving further down. She trails the kisses down, her mouth watering in anticipation.

Catra gives the hard nub of her nipple a peck before catching Adora’s eyes. She wants to enjoy all of this, Adora’s reactions included. It's not just because this is her first, her first with Adora, but it also might very well be her only night with this ethereal woman that by fate's graces she’s been allowed to meet. Catra flicks with her tongue, watching with awe at the way Adora’s lips part. These moments are the ones she’s going to steal and lock away. Adora looks absolutely divine. Her own fire is forgotten as she teases Adora’s other breast, sharp flicks across the nipple with her thumb.

Strong brows are pinched tight as Adora grinds down on Catra’s legs. She starts to rock her leg against her, not just a tease this time. The hands on her shoulders clench as Adora throws her head back with a quiet, panted “fuck”.

The thought crossed her mind before they started making out to turn the lamp off, but now she’s glad she didn’t with the way the soft light accentuates the shadows of Adora’s clenching jaw. With departing peck, Catra lifts herself back up, taking one of Adora’s hands from her shoulder and laces their fingers together. Adora’s legs wrap around Catra’s waist, pulling her in closer. It doesn’t take long before the kiss turns desperate, heavy inhales with each rock of Catra’s thigh. She gets a steady rhythm going, both of them moving in tandem. Catra’s arm is starting to strain from the effort of holding herself up while doing this, but like hell is she

going to stop. Every time Adora arches toward her fuels her will to keep going. Adora's so wet that Catra feels the damp through all three layers of fabric between them and the thought makes her dizzy. She wants to feel her there, but she also doesn't want to stop what's happening already just yet. Catra needs more hands, because the options are to fall on top of her or unlace their fingers, and she needs that space to keep the rhythm going.

Catra cups her face, stroking along Adora's cheek with her thumb. She stares into those icy blue eyes like she could find religion there. Maybe she already has, with how much devotion Catra already has with touching her soft skin. "Come on, angel." Adora moans louder as she pulls Catra in for a kiss that's just as frantic as her hips are. The grip in her hair is painful but Catra can't help but moan with her as Adora shudders beneath her, gasping and whimpering Catra's name over and over again against her lips.

"Fuck, Catra." Adora groans as her body laxes between heavy breaths, running her hands up and down Catra's sides, and they just can't seem to stop kissing. Adora wraps her arms around Catra, pulling her flush against her and rolls them over onto their sides.

"Did—" Her lips are so soft, so warm, so all consuming. Adora's hand brushes down Catra's back, and dips beneath the waistband of her sleep pants. She squeezes Catra's ass and Catra feels like the driest tinder, ready to catch flame faster than those newspapers probably did. Her pussy actually *aches,* clamping down on nothing. She needs Adora to do something, but once that starts Catra doesn't think she's going to be able to stop, and she wants to feel Adora more first. "Did you—"

Adora pulls back finally, looking at her with those heartbreakingly big, blue eyes and barks out a huffy, disbelieving "Ha!" She peppers Catra's neck, and full on octopus clings to Catra, throwing her leg over her too. "Did I? *Yes,* very. That was—" Catra feels her shake her head. "You are amazing, babe."

Catra shivers at the pet name, or at the way Adora's finger is edging ever closer to where Catra wants her so badly, probably spurred on by the fact that she'd forgone underwear when she slipped into pajamas. (She absolutely was not going to back down stairs for her things once Adora brought her to her room.) All that aside though, Catra felt — triumphant? No, that's not quite it. Adora isn't a thing conquered. She was amazing, funny, sweet, beautiful and Catra just made Adora chant her name over and over as she came undone beneath her. She wants to do it again, forever, in infinitum.

Catra loops a finger around Adora's waistband and tugs it tentatively. "Can we take this off? Also um, can I touch you again? Are you up for it?"

The pecks on Catra's neck stop as Adora pulls back into view. "Yeah, I can take them off. You too?" Catra must have made a face, because Adora makes a face and pouts concernedly. "If you aren't comfortable with me touching you—"

Catra shakes her head vigorously, flushing. That's the furthest from what she wants. "No, it's not that. It's uh…" she swallows "I don't know if… I'll be capable of doing anything more to you, once you start."

The gentle look of concern on Adora's face turns into a smirk. "Oh." She says, fucking smug and sexy. Catra has half a mind to snap the elastic of Adora's pants against her skin. "Well, you can still take them off, if you want. I can wait."

Catra takes a deep breath. "That would be nice." Without really thinking about it she removes herself from the tangle of limbs and slides off of the bed. She pulls them down, stepping out of them unceremoniously. Catra is halted from getting back on the bed because Adora had quickly sat up and is now just *looking* .

Fighting the shyness, Catra tries out her usual bold flirtation, just naked this time. No big deal. "Like what you see or something, doll?" Catra asks, placing her hands on her hips.

“Aces.” Adora says with a smile and shake of her head before beckoning her back to the bed with grabby hands.

“Aces, lord, you’re evil, you know that?” Catra says with a laugh. ‘Aces’, Adora’s probably never going to let that one go. Catra wants her to be around enough for her to never let that go.

“Oh really? I’m pretty sure you called me ‘angel’, change your mind already?”

“Not a chance, you are an angel.” But what Catra really wants to call her is ‘my angel.’ So much so that even though Adora is wrapping her into an embrace as she crawls back on the bed, there’s an almost overwhelming sense of yearning for this person who is right here.

There’s a lot going on right now in Catra’s head. For one, there’s the flippy, tangled knot in her stomach that gets more tangled every time she thinks about how special Adora is. For two, there’s the self consciousness around being nude in front of a lover for the first time, but largely there’s a nervousness about what she’s about to attempt to do. While she did just make Adora come already (amazing), she still has absolutely no idea what she’s doing.

Catra doesn’t look as Adora kicks off the rest of her clothing, taking to tracing her hip with her fingertips instead. She chews on her lip, looking at Adora intently with her flushed cheeks, soft, kissable lips, and her long, beautiful, mussed hair. All she has to do is move her hand a little over and into the darker curls there and this gorgeous face will twist in pleasure again, hopefully.

She’s about to move but then notices how stiff Adora looks, how stiff and unmoving the hand Catra’s shoulder feels. Catra knows why she is nervous, but why is Adora? She shrugs Adora’s arm off of her, picking up the hand and promptly pulling it to her lips, coaxing those knuckles to relax. “You okay?”

Adora looks surprised. “Yeah. I’m fine. More than fine, I’m just not sure what to do with my hands. You said not to touch you but then I was already holding you when you crawled back in …”

Catra can’t help but laugh as she flips Adora’s palm over, bringing kisses there too. “You can *touch* me, Adora. I just meant not *there*.”

“Oh!” Adora exclaims, visibly relaxing again.

“Dork.” Catra mumbles affectionately into her hand. Apparently Adora heard that because she squeezes her hand around Catra’s mouth, squishing it in.

“How about you? You seem pretty nervous still, and that’s okay.” Adora says as she lets Catra’s face go, hand coming to rest under her chin instead. “I can see it in your eyes.”

“I— I am.” Catra admits. For as much as she can see in Adora’s ocean blues, Catra isn’t that surprised that she can read hers just the same. What if she’s bad at this? Adora’s been with other people before, experienced people probably. It’s not like Catra doesn’t know where the clit is or anything, but everyone’s different in what they like. Scorpia told her as much, describing things she’s done with other women, because Catra asked, even though she pretended to read her book and ignored her as Scorpia prattled on, inventing questions she thought Catra might ask.

“My first time,” Adora pulls Catra in closer, nestling them up together again. “I was already so riled up from listening to the baseball game earlier that day, the Sox lost, and I was so nervous, I kind of just steamed on ahead at full charge.” Catra blinks at her, watching Adora’s smile grow as she in turn watches Catra. “I leaned down to kiss her,” Adora says wistfully, “and headbutted her so hard she got a bloody nose. So far, I think you’re doing so wonderfully, so careful and kind.”

Catra almost laughs, she can definitely picture it with the way Adora kisses. Any gal would be lucky, headbutt or not to be on the receiving end of that. Instead though, Catra let's the hand on Adora's hip slide over until it's brushing along soft curls. "What if," Catra says quietly, leaning into the stroke of Adora's thumb and advently avoiding meeting her eyes. "I'm bad at it? I don't want to disappoint you."

Even though Catra's mostly talking into the pillow, Adora manages to make contact with the corner of her mouth in a chaste kiss. "You're not going to disappoint me, and it's not going to be bad." Catra raises her brow in argument, and Adora huffs. Catra's overheard enough women talking to know just how 'not good' their lovers can be. "It's not going to be bad," Adora repeats. "if it doesn't feel good, I'll tell you, and we can adjust. I can show you how I like it, with as many hands-on demonstrations as you need." Adora ends with a teasing voice, pressed right up against Catra's ear.

Catra fully buries her head in the pillow again to hide just how much she'd like that. She takes a moment for the grin on her face to calm down before readjusting. All she needs is to just take the dive, lower her hand those few inches and hopefully be so lost in the sounds Adora makes that it overrides what a twit she's being. Even if she's clumsy it won't be a trip for biscuits. Adora reassured her as much.

Catra bumps her nose against Adora's, prompting a soft and sweet kiss as she slides her hand down, one finger lined up to feel for the nub she's looking for. Adora's so wet she almost slips right past it, but Catra feels it and brings her finger to the base of Adora's clit and begins a hard, slow circular motion like how Catra likes to start off when she's doing this to herself.

The kiss stutters and Catra smiles, pulling back to watch Adora's flutter eyes close. A soft moan leaves her lips and Catra is the one that whispers "Yes." Adora nods weakly in agreement, running her hands along Catra's back and through her hair. She stays at that pace for a while, soaking in the breaths against her skin, the feel

of Adora beneath her fingers, not speeding up until Catra starts to renew the many marks on Adora's neck.

Once the rise and fall of Adora's chest quickens again, she speeds up with broader circles of her fingertips. She's so hot under Catra's touch, and so wet, Catra resists the sudden compulsion to bring her fingers back to her lips, mouth watering at the thought of tasting her. That can happen later.

Without a shirt to cling to, Adora's hand is fisted tight in her hair, guiding her head back up for a messy kiss. The biggest struggle is to keep her fingers in the right spot as Adora squirms. Between the tug in her hair, Adora's moans, and the tongue running along her own, Catra is completely and utterly wrecked. She keeps squeezing her thighs together, gasping along with Adora as if they were back in the theater again, Adora blacking out any thoughts other than want, need, and love.

Adora grabs Catra's wrist and she stops, worried for a second that she's being too rough until Adora tugs her hand down further. "In, *please* ." The words sound raw and wanting and that please is devastating as unnecessary as it is. Catra would and will gladly give Adora whatever she wants.

"You are so- so impossibly sexy." Catra groans as her finger dips inside, resting her head against Adora's. This is something she doesn't normally do to herself, and with this she actually is totally lost. Catra pulls out and pushes back in tentatively, pressing her finger along the heat inside.

"You can use two, beautiful." Adora whispers, taking over the motion on her clit herself. "Curl them in a bit." she adds with a shaky breath.

She adds the second finger easily, and repositions herself lower for a better angle. There's a spot that feels different, and Catra presses into it, rubbing against with the pads of her fingers while she's in up to her knuckles. "Catra! Yes!" Adora pants, and with it Catra can feel herself drip down her thigh. That's the spot,

apparently, so Catra focuses on it again as she pulls out and back, tapping her fingers when she reaches there again as her pace quickens.

It's still a bit clumsy, but Catra manages to find a steady rhythm. She wants to say sexy, sweet things to her in return but it's taking all she has to maintain composure with the embodiment of everything good half screaming her name. Her mouth is busy anyway, sucking and nipping her way across Adora's chest. Where Catra likes things soft, Adora seems to prefer a harder touch. She matches the pace Adora sets over her own clit and is rewarded with toe curling, thigh clenching, back arching, heaven. Each gasp rises in crescendo, the finest sounds coming forth until Adora stills, body taught and her mouth opens in nothing but a sob. It's really obvious to Catra now when Adora comes this time, her walls rolling over Catra's fingers, the way Adora tenses, lips pursed in a blissful agony. Catra doesn't want to see anything else.

Adora is still catching her breath when Catra breaks. She's been one stiff breeze from igniting this whole time, and that was by far the hottest thing she's ever experienced. Gently pulling out she takes her hand and immediately starts the slow motion around her own clit, moaning at both the touch and Adora's slick now working toward her own orgasam. Catra's desperation doesn't go unnoticed by Adora who responds by flipping them over, kissing her with whole hearted attention as Catra tips ever closer to release.

Adora's long hair is ticking over Catra's chest, the weight of her body is like an anchor and then Adora just had to go and say "Can I go down on you?" in a sinful, husky voice. That was all she needed before muffling the sobs of release into Adora's shoulder. If the last hour and half of buildup hadn't happened, Catra just might have lasted long enough to say yes. Instead, electricity comes cascading through her body, all tongue and teeth and instinct to cling to her lover as it shudders over her.

Soft pecks and gentle caresses on her thighs bring Catra back down, her heart only hammering half as hard as it had been just

minutes ago. A wave of sleepiness washes over her and Catra wraps her arms around Adora, clinging to her as if she were the warmest blanket on the coldest of nights. Every little peck to her neck is a seal on her fate, burning Adora's name on her heart as if the brand on her mind wasn't enough already.

"Was it good? Like how you imagined this time?"

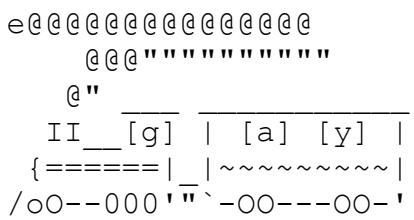
Catra nods her head, eyes still closed and offers a tired hum. "Better than." she mumbles, petting lazily through soft silky hair. "You?"

"It was perfect. You're perfect." Adora answers with a kiss on her nose, and then her cheeks are aching once more from the smile across Catra's face. "We can go to sleep if you want, but my question still stands."

"Hmm?" Catra is halfway to sleep, the tide of it washing over her, images of waking up with this goddess in her arms.

"If I can go down on you." Adora whispers into her ear.

That little sentence is more effective than any cup of joe or blast of the horn from a train at waking her right the hell back up.



———-

Everything aches in a pleasant way, the air is dense with the scent of sex, they both definitely need to take a shower again but the biggest sign that it's finally time to sleep is the sound early birds chirping outside of Adora's window.

“We should…” Catra murmurs, feeling the curve of Adora’s waist beneath her palm, the pockets of softness hidden between muscles.

“sleep.” Adora finishes into Catra’s ear. But Catra arches her neck to the side, giving Adora the go ahead to take her earlobe between her teeth once more. Catra puts all her effort into trying to show Adora the same appreciation of her body, but all she can manage is a weak squeeze on her posterior.

The delightful toying on Catra’s ear lulls into nothing so she tips her head back just in time to see Adora’s eyes flutter open again. Catra smiles and Adora flashed her own pearly whites as they both chuckle. “Sleep.” Catra says simply and then grimaces as her thighs unstick when she goes to stretch. Catra brings a hand up to her face, itching the skin and little flecks of dried, *well, that*, peeling off onto her fingernails. Or maybe it was from her fingers? “Gross…” she groans, which just makes Adora laugh harder.

“Shower first? It’s small but… I think we can manage to both fit in there.” Showering separately would probably be more efficient, less distraction for sure, but the thought of leaving Adora’s side right now makes her heart quake.

The hot water is just what she needed, warmth soothing muscles Catra didn’t know she had. Adora’s arm is slung across her chest as they just stand there for a while, and it feels so good, so right, so perfect to be in her arms like this. A shower shouldn’t be a holy experience, and Catra’s had some amazing showers after traveling for days. Nothing could ever compare to this though, the sheer intimacy of it.

Catra feels high, tired and content, her heart bursting when Adora drapes a towel over her. They re-enter the room quietly, save for the clearing of Adora’s throat and paragraph filled glance as Adora takes the sheet from her bed. The blankets were largely spared, having been pushed to the side at round two. Adora sighs and goes back into the bathroom for more towels.

Adora settles herself on Catra's shoulder, legs intertwined with the blanket draped over them. She looks so tired, so happy, and like love. There's something else there though that Catra can see as she runs her fingers through Adora's hair.

"Do you ever think you'll settle down somewhere?" She asks quietly. Catra can barely keep her eyes open but she keeps her gaze fixed on the blues looking up at her though long lashes anyway.

"Some day." Catra says hoarsely. She never thought it would be so soon, or that it would be Chicago, but it looks like someday is tomorrow, *today* really. She's too tired to talk about it properly now so Catra goes with her original thoughts, saving the rest for after breakfast, after she can talk to her family. "I still want to travel for a while. It's not like anyone can really make a life right now. Especially for a gay woman. No one wants to hire us, and with no man well…" she gives a small shrug. "If I'm going to be broke, might as well do it while seeing things, ya know?"

There's a bit of silence, and then Adora frowns. It might as well be poison on her heart for how much that frown hurts. Catra is about to reassure her that while that was her plan, those changed when Adora speaks up again. "I've barely been outside of Chicago. It's really neat, hearing about all those places you've been. I want to see that waterfall you all camped under. The furthest I've been is just a little town an hour or so south of here, my grandmother's farm." That jaw dropping smile returns and Catra relaxes. "My mom used to take me out there, and the three of us would go pick berries and asparagus. What I remember the most though is how beautiful the stars are. You can't really see them here, too much light."

"Yeah," Catra adds wistfully, thinking of the many nights she and Rogelio would lay silent in the grass, looking out at the great Milky Way, him pointing out different constellations and planets named of warriors long past. "they are really pretty."

Her face is turned back down by Adora’s thumb, who’s looking at her with an intensity that makes Catra have to swallow the words ‘I love you’ back off her tongue.

“When you look at me, like that,” Adora says with a kiss to Catra’s cheek. “It’s like seeing the stars again.”

It’s like an sledge hammer hit her square in the chest, knocking the wind out of her. Catra kisses her until she physically can’t anymore.



Chapter End Notes

Thank you, Rin for the gorgeous art. I love all the little details on the cork board and just how amazingly soft they look.

18+ Rin can be found @Duskrin on Twitter. OG twit post : https://twitter.com/duskrin/status/1625632191224123392?s=46&t=SrYeBjw05gbE0kTacnboGQ

As always, would love your comment and kind words. I know for me, smut is hard to comment on, but there's plenty o fluff here too.

Sorry if there's any mistakes, I'll probably find 3 right after I post this.

Ehhh Lolo (nudge nudge) did ya catch the references, or did you eat too much caramel?

A Lavender Goodbye

Chapter Summary

> There's talk of hanky panky, some kitchen utensil violence, gangsters, time period crossing jokes. Idk, hope you like this weird thing I've made.

Chapter Notes

> I never thought I'd talk about hot dogs so much.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They definitely overdid it last night. Catra's lips feel bruised, stinging from the good morning kiss that she wakes to. The sting is worth it though, for how sweet it is, it's just a reminder of where honey comes from.

"Wha' time is it?" Catra slurs, the temptation to shut her eyes again voided by the way the sun caresses Adora's messy hair and rosy skin.

"Who cares?" Adora mumbles back, her stomach growling audibly as she pulls Catra into the crook of her neck. She is so damn warm and soft. Catra doesn't really care what time it is, other than it's too fucking early. All Catra wants to do is spend the entire day with her skin flush with Adora's, but she can't, not yet. She needs to talk with her family before that can happen.

"You struck me as a morning person," Catra says with a kiss to the soft part of Adora's throat, then again and again until she makes it up to Adora's chin. "The really annoying kind that's whistling as soon as they're out of bed." The arm around her shoulders pulls her even closer, somehow. Yup, she could stay like this for the rest of her life.

"I don't whistle…" Adora says into Catra's hair. "…but you're not wrong. I am a morning person. I just don't want to stop this." The

way Adora's stroking through her hair and across her back, sending trickles of electricity down Catra's spine, is making it so, *so* very hard to argue, not that she wants to. "But…" Adora adds as she leans away, glancing toward her nightstand, "we haven't missed breakfast yet. Glimmer would have come and got me." She adds a thoughtful hum as she stares at the clock. "We're only open till 10:00 on Sundays. So it's the one day we always have breakfast, well, brunch at 10:30. We can snuggle for ten more minutes? Then get dressed?" Adora looks back at Catra, as if the answer to that could ever be no.

"Hmmm… I don't know, doll." Catra taps her chin thoughtfully. "Why in the world would I want to do that? I was actually thinking I could get togged to the bricks and go back to that hotdog stand, see if I can't score a hot date tonight with the weiner slinger." Adora's face puckers up in disgust, like she'd just bitten the sourest green apple and Catra *giggles* at it.

"Be my guest," Adora says with a shudder, but then gives Catra a coy smile. "I was going to ask you if you wanted me to use my tongue for those ten minutes, but never mind now."

"Oh nooo!" Catra reaches up and takes Adora's face in her hands. "I take it back. I'd much rather lay here with the most amazing woman I've ever met. I'll never eat a hotdog again! No coneys or-" a finger to her lips cuts her off.

"Ah, we don't speak of coneys in this city. It's a Chicago sin." It's compulsive, to kiss her, giving Adora's finger a peck as it departs her lips.

"Well have you ever had one, you goober?"

"Of course not, I'm not a heathen. It's either with ketchup or fully loaded." Adora's voice is so sweet and playful. Contrary to her proclamation of being turned off, she's leaning ever closer, knee finding its way between Catra's.

“Hmm, sucks for you then, angel. You’re missing out.” This conversation shouldn’t be making Catra’s heart flutter, but there Adora is with raised brows, hand trailing up the outside of Catra’s thigh, smiling like someone who’s just tasted chocolate for the first time.

“Mmm, I don’t think I am. I’ve missed out on a lot in my life. I think I’ve just started to not,” Adora pauses for a moment, an interesting look passes over her face that Catra can’t quite make out. It’s gone in a flash though, with another kiss pressed ridiculously hard to her cheek, sound effects and all. “,but I’ll still pass on that one.”

Catra traces her thumb along Adora’s lower lip before leaving a light kiss there. “I think I could live with Chicago-style from now on.” If they truly only have a few minutes before heading up to the apartment, then for as much as Catra wants to stay here, she needs to go find the others and start her goodbyes. The thought of leaving them hurts, but the thought of not seeing this face everyday is just inconceivable. It’s not a rash decision this time, that would first require it being a choice at all.

With mutual protest, they both slip out of the bed. It feels weird not to be touching her, but she needs to put last night’s quickly discarded pajamas back on in order to head down to the ballroom where her suitcase rests. “I’m going to head downstairs, get dressed properly. I might be a minute though because I need to run something past my friends. Should I meet you back in here, or at the storefront?”

“Uh, the storefront is fine. I need to talk to you about something too… after breakfast maybe?” Adora says hopefully, chewing her lip and looking like a far too cute, unsure, bedraggled mess. Catra was already thinking the same thing.

Catra grabs Adora’s hand and kisses the back of it. “Sounds perfect, angel.” It's silly how hard it is to let her hand go, the loss of her touch creating an invisible pull. For now though, it’s time to go back in the closet and down the stairs.

She braces herself for an immediate hounding by Lonnie, or Scorpia's endearing, awkward, support, but the once bustling Brightmoon Ballroom is empty aside from bags they all brought with them. Great, they all went upstairs already. Now she was going to have to single them out after their meal.

It doesn't take long to pick out clothes, not with this probably becoming one of the rare occasions she'll get to dress how she wants. Nothing too fancy, not that she owns anything like that, but nice enough to announce that you're abandoning your family for a woman you just met but can't imagine leaving without ripping your heart to shreds.

Catra is applying a light pomade to her hair when the stairs behind her creak with footsteps. She turns around just in time to see the smarmy look on Lonnie's face that she'd expected.

"Oh, so you are going to come upstairs. Not going to spend all morning making whoopie with that tragically good looking dame of yours?"

Catra's originally planned "Shut the hell up," was replaced with a brow lift instead.

"What? I have eyes." Lonnie says with a shrug, but then steps closer to elbow Catra's side. "I also have ears."

"No shit." Catra sighs, knowing exactly where this is going.

"Good job by the way, from what we heard through the walls, you're a natural."

As per usual, Lonnie is unphased by Catra's look of vile and vitriol. It's also fair to say that Catra might have made entirely unnecessary comments in the past that justify this, but making Rogelio blush is well worth it. It's the little moments of sisterly teasing like this in between the comfortable innocuous ones that Catra is going to miss the most. God knows how insufferable Lonnie is going to become without Catra's reality checks. Kyle might actually come to think he's the funny one.

“At least Scorpia isn’t going to be weird about it.” Lonnie adds with a coy smile. “She didn’t stay down here last night, went upstairs with a blondie of her own.” Catra’s surprise must be plain on her face because Lonnie adds a “you’re telling me!” to bring Catra out of her stupor.

“Well, good for her.” Catra says with a hard swallow. Hopefully whatever romance Scorpia got up to in the night will help lessen the sting of Catra’s news. That or it’s only going to make it harder to tell her, bursting that cotton candy muscle’s bubble. Lonnie might be able to help with that too. “There’s uh, actually something I need to talk to you about, all of you actually.”

“Hmmm, let me guess. You’re staying here?”

Catra must look as stunned as she feels, because Lonnie sighs and rolls her eyes. “Am I really that obvious?” she asks with a swallow.

“Yeah Cat, ya are. I had a hunch the moment we walked down here and you and your broad were both cute and awkward as hell.”

That both warms and annoys Catra. It’s a reassurance in some way that she’s not doing something completely off her rocker stupid because she had the same hunch the day they met Kyle in Baltimore. That bean pole really thought he could fight off a bunch of punks on his own, defending the cross dressed man that got caught stepping outside for some air at an alleyside speakeasy. He was lucky that she, Rogelio and Lonnie had been walking past. Kyle might have ended up snug in a Chicago overcoat otherwise. The three of them were able to scare off the goons, the man Kyle intervened for only had a couple scuffs to speak of, but Kyle himself turned out looking rather rough around the edges.

“You know,” Catra says softly, closing her suitcase back up, “I thought I was going to lose you and Ro when we met Kyle.” She looks up at Lonnie who looks no less smarmy than before, but

there's a soft seriousness there now. "The way you both doted on him, babying every bruise and cut, and him laughing through the pain. Ro even smiled, I think that was the first time I've seen him smile."

"Hey, he smiles all the time."

"I still don't believe you, but I guess I can get how you saw this coming." Catra looks back down at her suitcase, fingers tracing the scratches in the leather, rubbing the soot-stained tweed wraps across it. She's not going to get to live out of this thing much longer. She purchased it with the first bit of cash she made out on the road, the burlap sack she left with didn't do much to protect her clothes against the rain. It was built to last and she didn't imagine retiring the thing so soon. If anyone left, she thought it would be Scorpia.

It's not like Catra never thought she'd meet someone. She just thought feeling like her soul's on fire when she's around Adora was only meant for people like Scorpia, or Lonnie, Kyle and Ro. People who didn't run away when things got real, who cared so much for every wayward soul that they came across. Even when she was a kid, the storybook love seemed so impossible to her, and yet here Catra was, closing a packed suitcase for the last time just to be with a woman she met yesterday.

"Is this crazy?" Catra says with a laugh and shakes her head. "What am I doing, Lon? I've never felt like this before. I'm not even nervous about her. I'm nervous to tell Scorpia but, I'm so sure about *her."*

Lonnie leans against the bar, chin in hand and shakes her head right back. "I've always thought you were messed up, Cat, an ego too big for your britches, unwarranted self-confidence when you never even score, but I don't think this is crazy. I think this might be the most normal thing you've done."

"Wow, thanks. Glad to know what you finally think now that I'm leaving." Catra scoffs, but smiles anyway. "I uh, I really do love

her. I just hope it’s something real, not just being dizzy, you know?”

“Well, guess you’re going to find out. If it doesn’t work out, you know where we’ll be in the winter, and all the places we stop that you can write to.”

Catra just nods, awkwardly flattening her nicest button down to try to avoid giving away her fluster. She clears her throat and turns to present herself. “What do you think? I don't look doggy, do I?” Lonnie shakes her head and laughs, but then she draws a deep breath and closes the distance between them, wrapping Catra in a Scorpia-level hug.

“I'm going to miss you,” Lonnie mumbles into her shoulder. Catra clutches her back with all the intensity of the crash of emotion roiling through her. SheCatra feels her chest tighten and she clenches her teeth as the tears threaten to form.

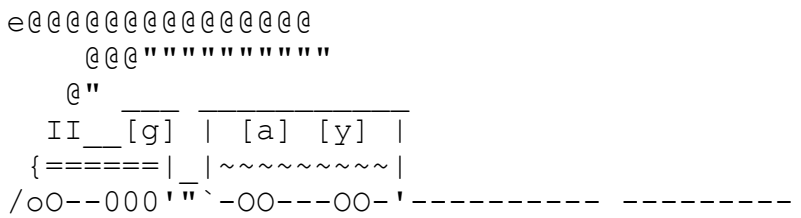
“I’ll miss you too, so much, sis.” Ah fuck it, better now than later with an audience. As soon as Catra stops fighting it, a few tears make themselves known, and Lonnie must be able to tell because she crushes Catra tighter. “Don’t let anyone take advantage of Scorp, or Kyle. Their hearts are too big.” Catra says with a sniffle, suddenly wishing they could all stay here too. Even with Adora’s company, the days are going to be long without the people she’s spent nearly every day with for the better part of nearly four years.

“So is yours, you big softie.” Lonnie claps her back and pulls away, leaving Catra to wipe off the wetness on her cheeks. “Don’t worry, I won’t tell anyone what a big baby you really are.” Lonnie smiles, clearly near shedding a tear or two herself.

“You do all the time already, ass.” With a deep breath and hoping the evidence of her crying is well and gone Catra swings an arm around Lonnie’s shoulders and ushers them both to the stairs.

“So, is she really that amazing, or are you -“

“Shut the hell up.”



The top floor of the building is definitely a tight fit, the living room adorned with enough seating for all its residents, and the dining room is even more so with the addition of five guests. Adora doesn’t drop Catra’s hand at all, at least keeping to touching fingertips as they scoot past people who are already seated. They do lose contact as Adora pulls out a chair for Catra, and Catra suddenly feels keenly aware of all the eyes on them. Bow and Scorpia are giving them looks like they just saw a puppy, Glimmer is trying and failing to avoid eye contact with a tight lipped smile, and both Kyle and Rogelio are watching Catra smugly, for some fucking reason. Mr. and Mrs Queen enter with the last of the breakfast spread just as Adora sits and Catra retakes her hand. She is grateful for the silent support, because it feels like Mrs. Queen is staring straight into her soul.

Once the heads of this little kingdom take their seat, the food starts to get passed around. Nothing fancy: fried potatoes, scrambled eggs, and Catra is pleasantly surprised at the grits, salted and buttered. She and the rest of her group take the usual lesser portion when they are at a host’s house. With a glance, Catra sees Adora not take that much herself. She doesn’t get to pout at her long before Micha stands up and proceeds to shovel more on all their plates. Catra would be embarrassed if not for Adora getting that treatment too, and the cute little gaffa she lets out when another yet another heaping spoonful of eggs lands on Adora’s plate.

“I’m not even that hungry,” Adora mumbles, and everyone from the household rolls their eyes.

“If there’s only one thing Adora lies about,” Perfuma says as she leans over the table, fork in hand and poised to pluck something up off of Adora’s plate, “it’s that she’s not hungry.” Just as Perfuma starts to jab into a potato wedge, Adora parries it with her own fork and shields the rest of her plate by way of a well placed arm.

Catra laughs and leans into Adora’s shoulder. “Oh I already know not to come between her and food. That’s how I met her after all, saving a man from getting a beat down.”

This time the pout is directed at Catra and she melts a little inside. Catra presses her lips to Adora’s in a chaste peck, lingering just long enough to feel Adora’s lips curl into a smile. “And he’d’ve deserved it, angel.”

“Wow,” both Lonnie and Glimmer say in sarcasm-laced unison, and Catra can feel the heat in her cheeks rise, matching Adora’s rosey ones. Adora’s brows are furrowed though, and she glares at Glimmer. Catra knows Lonnie is just making fun of her, getting in as many jabs as possible before she can’t anymore. Anytime she does something particularly “Catra” (be suaver than Lonnie could ever be,) Catra is pretty sure she’s going to hear Lonnie’s scoff in her head. The short, sparkly one, however, has been giving a cold-cock look since she shuffled down the stairs last night. Envy doesn’t just come in green, it’s also in all the shades of purple Glimmer is donning.

“So, Scorpia,” Perfuma breaks the growing silence around the table and rests her hand over Scorpia’s. “I’m sure Angella would love to hear all about the haberdashery your family used to run that you were telling me about this morning. Her family is one of the largest textile producers-“

“On the other side of the pond,” Angella finishes for Perfuma, one finger raised for emphasis as if it’s quite the important detail. Ya

know, because they are all knowledgeable in the textile tycoon business. Catra is happy to have conversation going on around them though, because it delays the twenty questions that are plain on Angella's face. It also gives Catra ample room to continue her love drunk eye contact with Adora. At least, it would have, if not for the sudden sharp pain of a kick to the shin from under the table.

"Ah, you know. I think I left another sheet of potatoes in the oven. Looks like we could use a refill of the water pitcher too. If someone wants to help me with that," Glimmer says oh so nonchalantly, looking around the table, only pausing a bit longer at Catra as she scans the group. It wouldn't have been noticeable if not for the ways Glimmer's eyes grew obviously hard at the sight of her.

"I'll help you," Catra says with a sweet sing-song voice that makes Kyle stiffen.

The abruptness from which they both stand startles most of the table and Catra feels a hand on her arm. Adora is looking up at her confused until she glances at Glimmer and her face frumples into a glower. "You're our guest, let me."

"I got it," Catra says with that same sing-song and bright smile, giving Adora's shoulder a squeeze as she shuffles behind her. Catra follows her into the kitchen, barely rounding the corner before Glimmer turns on her heels and crosses her arms.

"So, what's your deal?" Glimmer's tone isn't nearly as venomous as her eyes, but it spikes Catra's blood pressure anyway.

" *Excuse me?!* What's *your* deal?! I haven't done shit to you, I barely know your name, Shimmer." Catra sneers right back. Glimmer's face turns a deep red and she grabs a pair of oven mitts from the counter, stepping closer to Catra and smacks her in the shoulder with them.

“You barely know Adora, but that hasn’t stopped you one bit from hurting her.” *Thump* “Do you think it’s fun to go around from town-” *Thwack* “*to* town charming your way into gal’s hearts and-” *Thump* “then leaving them high and dry?” Catra steps aside this time, snatching the oven mitts from Glimmer’s hands as they miss Catra’s shoulder. She huffs, but Catra’s silent *dare to try it again* glare puts Glimmer off.

Once Glimmer’s arms are crossed again, Catra tosses the mitts back on the counter, fighting the urge to smother the short stack with them. “Really, you’re no better than a skeezy man. This might be just some hanky panky for you, but Adora actually has feelings for you, for some damn reason.”

“I do *not* do that, and you’re making a *lot* of assumptions there,” Catra says through clenched teeth. “What makes you think I don’t care about her too, huh?”

“Oh, I don’t know.” Glimmer rolls her eyes, which fall back on her weapon of choice. She snatches them up before Catra can step between her and the counter. She tries though, and ends up pressed against the sink trying to dodge another swipe. Catra puts her hands up, but this time the blow lands on Catra’s painstakingly quaffed hair.

“Put the mitts down, you psycho!”

“Maybe it’s because you’re leaving today! Kyle was telling us all about it. You’re just going to hop a train and be on your way to break some other poor woman’s heart.”

Some of Catra’s anger melted away with the concern in Glimmer’s eyes that dwell under all of her seething, but that doesn’t stop Catra from grabbing Glimmer’s wrists and pulling them down and away from ruining her hair even more.

“They are leaving, yes,” Catra whispers, “but I’m not.”

Glimmer relaxes enough for Catra to let her go, and Glimmer takes a step back. “You’re not?”

"No, I'm not. It would break my heart as much as you say it would break Adora's. I can't do it. I haven't told anyone yet except Lon. Now can we go back so I can have one last meal with my family? *Please* ?"

Maybe it's the way Catra's voice breaks, maybe it's knowing that Catra isn't just some scamp toying with her best friend's feelings, but Glimmer softens and nods. "Yeah. Okay," She says quietly, and almost forgets the ruse that brought them into the kitchen in the first place. Glimmer wields the mitts once again to take the potatoes out of the warmer as Catra fills the water pitcher.

"Did you leave those in here on purpose just to pull me in here?"

"Maybe."

Adora is halfway out of her seat when they both stride back into the dining room. She stops mid-stand and searches between them before sitting back down. Catra just shakes her head slightly at Adora's quirked brow. She takes her seat again, grabbing Adora's hand under the table when Angella clears her throat.

"So, I wanted to ask you all… you are all vagrants by choice?"

"Mom! Tons of people are homeless right now and out of work. The Great Crash, ring any bells?"

"Don't be smart with me Glimmah, of course I know that. But not all of them are train-traveling vagabonds." Angella somehow sits up straighter, and makes pointed eye contact with each of her guests. Catra knows she probably looks uncomfortable, but it's not at the question. She's trying to kill the laughter in her throat from the matriarch's hoity toity word choices. How did this bougie British lady end up at a laundry service in Chicago, anyhow?

"Perhaps I should be more straightforward. Are you all running from anyone? In trouble with the law or dangerous men? You all seem very sweet, and I happen to know someone who can help if you wanted to safely settle down somewhere. Al owes me a favor, and I'd be happy to cash it in."

Glimmer groans and rests her head against the table. "Mom, please stop telling people Al *fucking* Capone-

"Language young lady!"

"-owes you a favor."

"He *does* owe me a favor. That man is no good with numbers. His taxes were just a *mess* . I didn't know who he was of course…" she waves her hand dismissively, as if accidentally currying favor from one of the most powerful gangsters in the country was no big deal. "But he's come in handy, with keeping our safe haven quiet. It's funny really, his brother James is a regular here- lot of stains to get out, leaves his briefcase-"

"Honey-" Micha starts until Angella pats him on the shoulder apologetically.

Kyle is looking at Catra like a deer caught in the headlights, the only one of them aside from her really paying attention. Ro and Lon are too busy stuffing their faces, while Scorpia looks strangely nervous. Catra's about to reach across the table to check in on her when Angella starts up again.

"Right, where was I? Oh, yes. I want to make sure you're not in any trouble." Angella cups her hand to her cheek and leans conspiratorially over the table. "So tell me, as you kids would say, what's the *down low?"*

Micha scoots his chair closer to the table and leans in with her. "I think it's *low down,* dear." He looks at Glimmer for confirmation. She doesn't say anything, resigning to hide her face in her hands. Hawk gives him a big thumbs up instead, which Mermista quickly lowers.

Both Lonnie and Rogelio both have their mouths full, which they point to and shrug. Genius. Catra grabs the crust of Adora's toast (she'd already eaten all of hers) and shoves it in her mouth so fast Adora has gone from staring at the tablecloth in horror to looking

at Catra, betrayed. Scorpia still seems lost in whatever worry she's having, Perfuma leaning in close to whisper to her.

Adora narrows her eyes at Catra's mouthful of stolen food. "U wern - onna." Catra tries to muffle out "You weren't gonna eat it," because she watched Adora eat around the crust, which, *cute* , but in her attempted communication, crumbs go flying into her windpipe and Catra's left coughing instead.

"I save it for cleaning up whatever's left on my plate!"

Everyone is somehow occupied aside from Kyle, who begins to wilt under Angella's gaze. "Um, no ma'am. We just uh. Well, uh, it's not like there's really any work anywhere. And uh, it's uh, actually safer for us. Rogelio, Lonnie and I can sleep close without worry. And uh, Catra and Scorpia can uh, yeah, be themselves?"

"And why is that?" Micha asks, earnestly.

"Well, um, sir, um." Kyle looks like he's about to choke on his tongue but Perfuma saves him.

"Safety in numbers I imagine. That and the fact that they probably don't see the same *wrong* people enough for them to catch on."

Kyle seems to finally balance in the spot he was put on and nods. "Yeah. There's also a lot of others like us. We can usually tell too. Like some sort of… hmm."

"Homosexual sonar," Adora suddenly pipes up excitedly, no longer preoccupied with watching Catra choke on her ill gotten food. "That's what I call it anyway. I twigged right away that Catra wasn't into men." Well, *almost* right away. She can let that part slide, can never be *too* careful before flirting.

Catra gasps, having downed half a glass of city juice to clear up her bread-induced coughing fit just in time. "Oh, you think I'm obvious? Your face was red as a tomato as soon as you looked at me. I don't think it's a radar as much as you're an obvious

homosexual beacon, doll. A great, blushing North Star that any other gal who looks up can see for miles."

The next thing Catra knows, Adora is cupping her chin, thumb gently caressing her cheek. "I'm the blushing beacon?" Adora asks coyly, and if her cocky smile doesn't make Catra's face hotter-

"Thank you for telling me, Kyle." Angella is far too used to the chaos that lives in this house to be distracted easily. "I've been told that you're all leaving today, but you're welcome to stay a day more if you need, or if you come through the Windy City again."

Catra watches Adora's smile fade, and her stomach does a twist to rival what they did on the dance floor last night. "Hey," she says quietly. "I need to talk to you about some-"

"I'm staying, actually."

Catra whips her head around to Scorpia, who is fidgeting with her napkin and looking between her and the rest of their group who's all done the same as Catra.

"Not here necessarily, but in Chicago."

"Scorp…" Catra starts, but is too stunned to find words to follow.

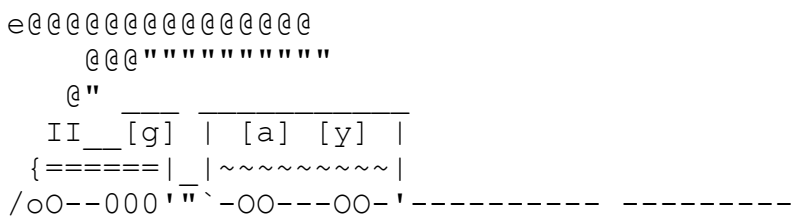
"Gosh, I've been doing this for a long time, and I think it's time for me to make a place home." Scorpia's eyes are starting to well up, and in an instant Perfuma grabs her hand. "Plus, I think I might, uh, want to stick around here for someone." Scorpia blushes and Catra can't help but smile. She deserves this, out of all of them. Scorpia so badly deserves love and a happily ever after. Looks like Catra won't be the only one leaving the steam engines behind her.

"You can stay here." Adora says suddenly, her mouth hanging open for a moment before swallowing hard. "Scorpia, you can have my room if that's okay with Angella."

"And where the hell will you stay?" Glimmer asks, taking the words right out of Catra's mouth. Adora turns to her then, only

stopping on her for just a moment before peering over Catra and at a shell shocked Lonnie, Kyle and a stone faced (upset) Rogelio.

“Can I come with you?”



Angella might not be her mother, but Adora knows a parental interrogation when she sees one. There’s a tight squeeze on her heart when she watches Glimmer and Bow leave the room with the others, dismissed after Adora’s announcement. She doesn’t even look mad, more resigned and sad than anything. Bow’s comforting glance doesn’t do much to quell the fear, excitement, sadness and joy tumbling around in a confusing mess inside her.

Once the door to the downstairs is closed, Adora holds Catra’s hand tight and faces a down-to-business Mrs. Queen.

“You’re sure about this, Adora?” Angella asks, her voice neither sharp or soft.

“Yes…” she breathes out, but then Angella keeps staring at her expectantly. “Okay, no, but also yes. I need change, Angella. I don’t really have a role here anymore, I leave every day just to try to find… something to do. I feel so useless here.”

“You do know that you don’t have to be *useful,* right, Adora?” Micha says softly. “We’ve been over this sweetheart, you’re family. We love you unconditionally like one of our own kids. If you’re feeling like a burden again… Is that why you haven’t been coming up for meals more often?”

"I know, I know, and I'm so thankful. You're family to me too." Adora ignores the last part of Micha's question, because yes, that *is* why. She's been managing to feed herself enough with her bar shift wages. "It's so much more than that. I want to see the world, but I spend every day just trying to bring money home, and I can't. But I *can* go see the world. Catra's shown me that. I can do that and be myself out there, instead of pretending to just be some *normal* gal."

"Adora," one of Catra's hands slides up her arm to rear on her shoulder, squeezing gently. "You- you know you don't have to right? That thing I was hoping to talk to you about, I was going to stay. I still can." She's caught her lower lip between her teeth and Adora's heart stutters again. "I couldn't leave you." Catra's words catch up to Adora, how fondly she'd talked about traveling with her family, all the places she's been, and yet, she was going to.

"Really?"

"Yeah, really." Catra says quietly.

Adora lets the silence stretch between them, forgetting for a moment that there's still other people in the room. It doesn't feel like silence though. It feels like three little words left unspoken. Part of her decision was Catra but all the rest was true too. She needed change, she needed to live for something that was just one day at a time, waiting for opportunities to fall at her feet. Adora had searched high and low for them for years now, and it was time to just start taking them, seeing what the rest of the wide world had to offer outside of these city streets that she's been trodding her whole life. "I still want to go. I want to go with you. Do you want that, too?"

Catra lets out a breathless "Yes" and kisses her. As nervous Adora still is about this sudden big change in her life that's about to happen, Catra's kiss makes her feel like she can do absolutely anything. Every fiber of her being is finally excited to see what tomorrow is going to bring. Adora doesn't remember why they are having this exchange until Micha coughs.

“It’s settled then, Adora? Is one of my birds leaving the nest?”

Adora takes Catra’s hand again and nods to Angella. “Yes.”

Angella stands abruptly and holds her arms out. “Well, come on then. I need a hug to get through this, then you should probably talk to Glimmer.”

She’s a bit too overwhelmed with everything to cry, or she probably would be. Adora rushes to the door, practically dragging Catra to it, when Angella calls out to ask for a word with Catra before she heads downstairs. “Ask” is putting it lightly. Angella is loving, respectful, and considerate, but all that kind of makes her impossible to say no to. Adora waits at the top of the stairs, ear pressed to the door, she can’t help it.

“You love her?”

“I- uh- um.”

“Dear, that’s really unfair to ask.”

“You do, don’t you?”

Adora is thankful that no one is in the stairwell with her because her eyes are probably bugging out of her head. She has half a mind to barge back in and save both of them from embarrassment, but then Catra speaks.

“Yes,” she says, but it’s muffled like she’s saying it through a mouthful of boiled eggs. “Yes, I think I do. I’ve never been in love before so, um, but yes. I love her.”

Adora is frozen, but there’s an unstoppable force welling into her chest. She can feel it rise from all the way down to her toes, like the water bursting through to the surface for the first time. It’s threatening to spring out in a squeal, but she silences it by slapping her hand over her mouth. She isn’t loony, Catra really does feel it too. She’s in love, and Catra loves her too!

“And you’ve only just met?” Angella asks.

That spring threatening to burst comes out just a little bit in a wide smile and well-muffled laugh when she hears Catra laugh in disbelief and a “Yeah, and yet, I love her.”

“You know, I think the French call it *le flash* ,” Micha says, chuckling to himself.

“They would, bloody perverts.”

Adora still has a mind to step a few paces down the stairs when footsteps sound, but she didn’t think to uncover her mouth. Her grin would give it away anyhow. Adora’s breath catches when Catra opens the door, and takes Adora in, blush rising all the way to her ears.

“You heard that, didn’t you?”

“Um…” Adora kisses her teeth and looks away to the wall. “Did I?”

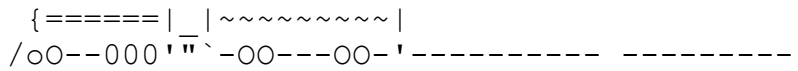
Catra sighs and comes to stand next to her. “I’m not ready, to uh, say it. So…” she rocks on her feet and Adora finally lets her hand fall from her face. That’s just fine with her. She *knew* already anyway, and she feels it too. This gorgeous, clever woman rocking on her heels, being bashful is someone Adora can see spending the rest of her life with, wherever that may be, but hopefully not Chicago.

“I like you, a lot.” Adora says instead, and takes Catra’s hand in hers.

“I like you a lot too, angel.”

She brings Catra’s knuckles to her lips and smiles. “Aces.”





Glimmer and Bow are nowhere to be found after Adora heads downstairs, but she takes a few hours to say her goodbye-for-nows, promising to write or ring the horn when she can. Her new travel companions have their own goodbyes to say to Scorpia. It doesn't take too long for her to pack either, only a few must have sentimental items, the small roll of cash she's saved up in case of emergency that Micha refuses to take from her. What takes the longest is what dress to pack. She'll rarely have to wear it now, but she ends up settling on one her mother used to wear. It's a bit out of style now, but along with the quilt and photo, she can take Mara with her to all the places her mother filled her head with as a kid.

Micha insists they can go dressed for travel instead of in proper clothing, just this once. They don't have to worry about a cabby apparently, so Adora doesn't stress too much about it. Even though it's nearly time to leave, Adora sits back down on her bed, taking in the room she's been in ever since Hawk and Mermista moved in. This room is where she had her first kiss with Starla, where she daydreamed about being a baseball star, about the Grand Canyon and the horses running wild in the Nevada desert. She might never throw a winning pitch, but at least some of these don't have to be dreams anymore.

"Hey," Glimmer says from the open doorway. Adora barely gets to stand up before arms are wrapped around her. She hugs Glimmer back with all the intensity and relief she feels that she isn't going to leave with her sister mad at her.

"I'm sorry, Glim. You know I love you and I-"

"It's okay, Adora. I get it. I wish you could be you outside this home. I know you and Perfuma have a hard time. She has always had to take the wig off, put the tie on, but you have a chance to be yourself outside of home. Just, be careful, okay?"

Adora doesn't let go, squeezing her tighter instead. "Aren't I always?"

"No," Glimmer replies curtly, and they both laugh. "Otherwise you'd've gotten a less troublesome girlfriend."

Adora hums to herself, pleased by the "g" word as they part.

"Come on then, everyone is waiting for you. Bow is already crying by the way."

There are an awful lot of tears at the front entrance when Adora gets there, and hugs too. Adora already talked to each of them, but everyone wants to send them off anyway. Netossa and Spinneralla even came back around, surprisingly well off for how hungover she heard they were this morning. The room goes silent when the front door opens though, a tall looming figure, visage blocked by the sun beaming on his back. He takes his officer's hat off and rests his head on the door frame.

"I can't believe my darling Adora is leaving us. You's better take good care of her, paloni-omi."

"Wally! What are you doing here?" Adora asks, relieved that the cop car parked behind him is void of another officer.

"Angella told me you's all needed a safe ride to the train depot. And of course I'm not gonna miss my chance to say goodbye. Entrapta sends her best. She'd be here but she's currently covered in oil, from our actual automobile. Otherwise I'd have taken that one instead."

There's lots more waving as Adora gets into the car, a few threatening looking words are exchanged between Glimmer and Catra, but Catra returns to her smiling. It's a lot to take in all at once. The excitement she feels that's filling up every lungful of air, the sadness of seeing her Lavender and Lye family shrink further in the distance, the curiosity of soon getting to know Catra's crew, and the comfort and love Adora feels from Catra's hand in hers.

“You alright, Adora? S’not too late to change your mind. I won’t be upset if you do.”

Adora buries her face into the crook of Catra’s neck and squeezes her hand tighter. “Yeah. I’m sure. I’m ready to start seeing what’s out there.”

“So uh, you’s really get away with that? On the road?” Wally asks from the front seat, eyes finding them in the rear view mirror.

“Yeah,” Catra replies, holding up their joined hands and then pecking Adora on the cheek. “We’re sisters, can’t you tell?”

Wally laughs, and Adora stares at their hands, the sharp contrast in skin tones. “I was adopted, obviously.”

“Obviously.” Wally parrots with a smile.

Chapter End Notes

I swear, “it was supposed to be short/ a one shot/ just smut” is going to be my epitaph.

Hope the ending didn’t feel too rushed. I didn’t want to repeat what was already done between Catra and Lonnie and I thought keeping that last bit short and sweet was the move.

Thanks for reading! Hope you enjoyed! Love all kudos and comments. I’ll update the last of the slang soon. I’m tired.

End Notes

Slang Index: As they pertain to this story. Some have multiple definitions. Will be added to as the story continues.

Cement mixer - Bad at dancing

Make Tracks - leave in a hurry

Jefferson- $2 bill

Cabbage - Paper Money

Egg - Crude person

Eggs in Coffee - Run smoothly

Evil - Bad mood

Cats & Alligators - Fans of swing music

Snipe - Cigarette

Clip Joint - Night club or Gambling hall where patrons get flim-flammed (deceived, but in this case its the "clip-joint" or speak easy that's deceitful in itself)

All Wet- no good

Tomato - Crude thing to call a beautiful woman (ripe for the picking)

Cinder Dick - Railroad Detective

Heater - A gun

Moll - Gangster's girlfriend

Dead hoofer - Bad at dancing

City juice (and not used yet but fun) Dog Soup - Water

Off the cob - corny

Trip for biscuits - task that yields nothing

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